

Reelationships

Personas

Persona 1: Campaign Orchestrator (Influencer Marketing Campaign Manager)

Name of the person	Anya Sharma
Tag line or Quote	“Brands tell me, ‘I want this creator at this CPV and engagement; just do it’—and all the pressure falls on intermediaries.”
Key Goals and Motivations	Sanjana aims to execute successful influencer marketing campaigns that meet brand-specified metrics like engagement rates, reach, and CPV while managing multiple stakeholders. She's motivated by delivering measurable results within budget constraints and maintaining relationships with both brands and agencies.
Environment Operating In	Works in fast-paced agency environments handling 2-3 clients simultaneously, operating between brands with large budgets (Dentsu) and smaller publishers (HarperCollins). Must navigate complex relationships between brands, influencer agencies, and individual creators while managing expectations across all parties.
What Are the Challenges	Receives harsh feedback from brands that must be diplomatically communicated to influencers, lacks comprehensive tools to evaluate influencer authenticity and performance, deals with brands imposing unnecessary restrictions, struggles with information asymmetry when evaluating influencer metrics, and faces time constraints when manually vetting large volumes of nano influencers.
What Tools are Currently used in the Context of the Problem?	Influencer marketing agency platforms (LV, Quiroz, Mad Influence), Instagram for direct outreach, manual analysis of competitor campaigns, and basic metrics dashboards that lack filtering and comparison capabilities.
Key Activities	Evaluates influencer performance through engagement rates, CPV, and CPM metrics; conducts competitive analysis by examining similar brand campaigns; negotiates with agencies rather than individual influencers; manages

	campaign timelines ranging from 2 weeks to 2 months; and acts as intermediary translating brand requirements to agency partners.
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Persona 2: Brand Decision-Maker (Marketing Manager at Large Brand)

Name of the person	Rohit Kapoor
Tag line or Quote	"I want this influencer at this cost and this CPV and this engagement rate. I don't care, just do it."
Key Goals and Motivations	Seeks maximum awareness and reach for established products while driving engagement and sales for new product launches. Motivated by achieving measurable marketing metrics and maintaining brand control over creative content and messaging.
Environment Operating In	Operates within large corporations (Reckitt, Unilever) with substantial marketing budgets spanning lakhs to crores, faces internal pressure to demonstrate ROI, and works within traditional corporate hierarchies that resist digital transformation.
What Are the Challenges	Lacks understanding of influencer authenticity and optimal fit between influencers and brand messaging, imposes irrelevant restrictions that create friction with influencers, makes decisions based on personal preferences rather than data-driven insights, and experiences resistance to adopting new digital tools or processes.
What Tools are Currently used in the Context of the Problem?	Relies heavily on influencer marketing agencies as intermediaries, uses traditional campaign management processes, and depends on agency-provided metrics rather than independent verification tools.
Key Activities	Sets campaign budgets and success metrics, approves or rejects creative content through multiple iteration rounds, makes final decisions on influencer selection often based on personal recognition rather than strategic fit, and delegates execution details to agencies while maintaining creative control.

Persona 3: Agile Marketer (Small Business Owner and Marketer)

Name of the person	Priya Singh
Tag line or Quote	"I want the turnaround time to be 20 days, right? I can't wait for 6 months for these people to get their content together."
Key Goals and Motivations	Aims to achieve cost-effective marketing impact with limited budgets, seeks quick turnaround times for seasonal or time-sensitive campaigns, and wants to build authentic connections with target audiences through relatable influencers.
Environment Operating In	Operates with tight budget constraints (50K-5 lakh range), faces time pressures for seasonal campaigns, lacks dedicated marketing teams, and cannot afford agency fees or minimum volume commitments required by larger platforms.
What Are the Challenges	Cannot access influencer marketing agencies due to volume requirements, must handle direct outreach and negotiations personally, lacks tools for evaluating influencer authenticity and performance, has limited time for manual influencer research and vetting, and struggles to compete with larger brands for premium influencer attention.
What Tools are Currently used in the Context of the Problem?	Direct Instagram outreach, manual competitive analysis of similar brands' campaigns, basic social media analytics, and simple negotiation processes without formal contracts.
Key Activities	Researches competitors' influencer partnerships manually, reaches out directly to nano and micro influencers via Instagram, negotiates rates and deliverables personally, manages campaigns without intermediary support, and relies on organic content performance rather than paid promotion.

Persona 4: Relationship Broker (Influencer Marketing Agency Account Manager)

Name of the person	Karan Mehta
Tag line or Quote	"They have that network and they have that relationship with influencers."

Key Goals and Motivations	Aims to maximize revenue through margin optimization between brand budgets and influencer costs, seeks to maintain relationships with both brands and influencers for repeat business, and strives to deliver committed metrics through volume deals and performance enhancement.
Environment Operating In	Manages multiple brand accounts simultaneously (typically 5 brands per POC), operates with substantial marketing budgets, leverages technology platforms for influencer aggregation, and maintains extensive networks of influencer relationships across categories.
What Are the Challenges	Must balance competing demands from brands seeking lower costs and influencers wanting higher rates, faces pressure to deliver committed metrics which may require content boosting, manages complex negotiations and creative feedback loops, and deals with brands resistant to platform-based solutions.
What Tools are Currently used in the Context of the Problem?	Proprietary influencer aggregation platforms, boosting capabilities for content promotion, volume deal management systems, campaign tracking and analytics tools, and relationship management systems for ongoing influencer partnerships.
Key Activities	Aggregates and categorizes influencers across different tiers and industries, negotiates rates with influencers using volume leverage, manages creative feedback and revision processes, boosts content performance to meet committed metrics, and maintains ongoing relationships with both brands and influencers for future campaigns.

Persona 5: Aspiring Creator (Nano Influencer)

Name of the person	Tanvi Jain
Tag line or Quote	"They are actually confused with how they want to grow their following because they think this is the way to achieve their dreams of earning money from content creation."
Key Goals and Motivations	Seeks to monetize their social media presence while maintaining authenticity with their audience, aims to build consistent income streams through brand partnerships, and wants creative control over content that aligns with their personal brand.

Environment Operating In	Often operates from home (many are mothers, housewives, homemakers according to the interview), may lack formal business experience, works directly with brands or through agencies, and maintains close relationships with smaller, engaged audiences.
What Are the Challenges	Faces pressure to modify their natural content style and voice to meet brand requirements, deals with multiple revision requests that increase workload, lacks bargaining power in rate negotiations, and may struggle with professional business practices and contract understanding.
What Tools are Currently used in the Context of the Problem?	Instagram as primary platform, basic content creation tools, personal devices for content creation, and simple communication channels (DMs, email) for business discussions.
Key Activities	Creates authentic content that resonates with their specific audience, responds personally to audience engagement, negotiates directly with smaller brands, adapts content style based on brand requirements, and maintains higher engagement rates through personal audience connection.

Problem Hypothesis

Jobs, Pains, and Gains Analysis

Type of Customer	Jobs/JTBDs	Pains	Gains
Campaign Orchestrator (Anya Sharma)	When I need to execute a successful influencer campaign, I want to quickly identify authentic, high-performing creators who align with my brand's target audience, so I can deliver measurable results within budget and timeline constraints	• Manually analyzing hundreds of influencer profiles without proper filtering tools • Cannot distinguish between boosted and organic engagement metrics • Translating harsh brand feedback diplomatically to maintain creator relationships • Time constraints preventing thorough vetting of nano influencers	• Access to comprehensive influencer authenticity data • Streamlined campaign management with clear performance benchmarks • Improved relationships with both brands and creators through better matching • Reduced stress from managing unrealistic expectations
Brand Decision-Maker (Rohit Kapoor)	When I need to maximize my marketing ROI, I want to select influencers whose audience perfectly matches my target demographic and brand values, so I can achieve measurable awareness and sales without compromising brand integrity	• Making influencer selections based on personal preference rather than data • Lack of understanding about authentic engagement vs. vanity metrics • Imposing creative restrictions that reduce campaign effectiveness • Agencies potentially overcharging due to information asymmetry	• Data-driven insights for optimal influencer-brand matching • Clear correlation between influencer metrics and business outcomes • Maintaining brand control while preserving creator authenticity • Transparent pricing and performance commitments
Agile Marketer (Priya Singh)	When I have a time-sensitive marketing campaign with limited budget, I want to quickly find and negotiate with relevant micro/nano influencers, so I can achieve cost-effective reach and	• Excessive time spent on manual influencer research via Instagram • Lack of negotiation leverage leading to unfair rates	• Rapid access to pre-vetted, budget-appropriate influencers • Fair, transparent pricing without agency markup

	authentic engagement for my target audience	• Cannot access influencer agencies due to minimum volume requirements • Difficulty vetting influencer authenticity within tight timelines	• Quick turnaround for seasonal and time-sensitive campaigns • Direct relationships with creators for better collaboration
Relationship Broker (Karan Mehta)	When managing multiple brand accounts, I want to efficiently match the right influencers with appropriate brands while maintaining healthy margins, so I can scale my business and deliver consistent results to all clients	• Pressure to deliver committed metrics through artificial boosting • Balancing competing demands between brands (lower costs) and creators (higher rates) • Managing hundreds of creator relationships across multiple brand accounts • Sustainability concerns as brands discover actual influencer pricing	• Sustainable margin models based on value rather than information control • Scalable systems for managing creator relationships and brand matching • Organic performance metrics that align with business outcomes • Long-term partnerships built on transparency and results
Aspiring Creator (Tanvi Jain)	When I want to monetize my social media presence, I want to partner with brands that align with my authentic voice and values, so I can earn consistent income while maintaining genuine relationships with my audience	• Brands requiring modification of natural content style and voice • Lack of professional business experience for contract negotiations • Confusion about balancing growth, monetization, and authenticity • Limited bargaining power leading to unfair compensation	• Brand partnerships that enhance rather than compromise authenticity • Fair compensation based on engagement and results rather than just follower count • Professional development support for business skills and career growth • Creative freedom within brand collaboration frameworks

Primary Problem Hypothesis by Persona

1. **Persona 1: Campaign Orchestrator (Anya Sharma):** Campaign managers struggle to accurately assess influencer authenticity and organic engagement because of lacking comprehensive tools to distinguish between boosted and organic metrics, forcing them to

rely on manual analysis of comment-to-view ratios and gut instinct when evaluating hundreds of potential influencers.

2. **Persona 2: Brand Decision-Maker (Rohit Kapoor):** Brand managers consistently select inappropriate influencers for their campaigns because of making decisions based on personal preferences and celebrity recognition rather than data-driven audience alignment, resulting in poor campaign performance and wasted budget.
3. **Persona 3: Agile Marketer (Priya Singh):** Small business marketers cannot adequately vet influencer authenticity for time-sensitive campaigns because of needing 20-day turnarounds while lacking tools to quickly assess organic engagement and audience fit, leading to partnerships with ineffective creators.
4. **Persona 4: Relationship Broker (Karan Mehta):** Agency account managers cannot maintain quality relationships with large influencer networks because of managing hundreds of creators while handling multiple brand accounts simultaneously, leading to standardized rather than personalized partnership approaches.
5. **Persona 5: Aspiring Creator (Tanvi Jain):** Nano influencers struggle with contract negotiations and professional communications because of lacking formal business experience and operating from home environments, making them vulnerable to unfair terms and unclear expectations from brands.

Appendix

Appendix: Personas

1. How did you select your interview candidates?

I focused on understanding the perspectives of key stakeholders across the entire value chain. This includes the buy-side (brands of various sizes), the sell-side (influencers with different follower counts), and the critical intermediaries that facilitate these relationships, such as marketing agencies and influencer aggregation platforms.

My goal was to get a complete picture by interviewing different types of people: brands, influencers, and intermediaries.

To find people to interview, I started by asking friends who work in marketing if they knew anyone relevant. They connected me with people in their networks. I reached out to 7 people total and ended up interviewing 5 of them, which gave me good insights into how this whole ecosystem actually works from different perspectives.

- **Sanjana Dixit:** Deep-diving into the operational mechanics of influencer marketing from an agency campaign manager's perspective. The interview examined the complexities of sourcing influencers at scale, the challenges of managing brand expectations vs. creator capabilities, and the inefficiencies in current platform and agency models.
- **Dhruv Gupta:** Exploring a brand's perspective on influencer marketing for B2B-to-B2C transition. The interview covered Dhruv's experience working with agencies, the ROI challenges of measuring influencer campaign success, and his future plans for direct influencer collaboration while moving away from expensive agency relationships.
- **Shourya Kumar Lal:** Understanding the creator ecosystem from a creator-filmmaker's perspective who also works with other influencers. The interview explored how creators prioritize metrics, manage brand relationships, handle contracts and agencies, and view influencer marketing as a stepping stone to broader entertainment careers.
- **Anupam Raj:** Understanding an emerging influencer's perspective on brand collaborations and payment structures. The interview explored Anupam's experiences with brands offering product-only compensation, his preference for fair monetary payment, and his strategy of focusing on content quality before actively seeking brand deals.
- **Dhreeraj Verma:** Examining the role of a talent manager/intermediary in the influencer marketing ecosystem. The interview focused on how Dheeraj sourced and matched influencers with brands, the challenges of negotiation and pricing standardization, and the pain points of managing relationships between brands and niche talent.

2. Who did you interview? Provide demographic information of all those you interviewed.

S. No.	Name	Role	Gender	Age	Location
1	Sanjana Dixit	Marketing Campaign Manager at Marketing Agency	Female	27	Hyderabad
2	Dhruv Gupta	B2B Platform Founder Who Has Hired Influencers	Male	25	Gurgaon
3	Shourya Kumar Lal	Short Film Director & Influencer	Male	24	Mumbai
4	Anupam Raj	Nano Influencer	Male	26	Hyderabad
5	Dheeraj Verma	Influencer Manager at Influencer Aggregator Agency	Male	25	Bangalore

3. Share the full recorded audio interviews as a link (to a shared folder) and provide the transcriptions below.

Audio Interviews Folder: [Interview Audio Files](#)

4. Affinity diagrams or likewise to determine the patterns in data to create personas.

Detailed Interview Analysis

Interview 1: Call with Anupam

Analysis of Verbal Cues

- **Confident and principled:** "I did not agree to that" - shows clear boundaries
- **Quantitative mindset:** Frequently cites specific metrics (4 million views, 30 days) indicating data-driven thinking
- **Long-term focused:** "This is my secondary kind of work" - positioning influencer marketing as supplementary, not primary income
- **Authenticity-oriented:** Repeated emphasis on "organic" content and avoiding "fake collaborations"

Key User Goals

- Focus on content originality and quality over immediate monetization
- Build authentic audience engagement without compromising personal brand
- Achieve fair compensation when ready to engage with brands (post-10K followers)

Main Motivations

- Content authenticity and maintaining genuine audience relationships
- Professional growth in primary career (influencer marketing is secondary)
- Results-based compensation rather than follower-count based payment
- Creative control and brand alignment

Key Frustrations and Pain Points

- Brands offering only product compensation instead of fair payment
- Exploitation of small creators with low-value propositions
- Communication inefficiencies through Instagram DMs (messages get lost)
- Lack of standardized, results-based compensation models

Opportunities

- **Results-based payment platform:** Compensation tied to actual performance metrics (views, shares) rather than follower count
- **Communication management system:** Better than Instagram DMs for brand-creator conversations
- **Creator education:** Help emerging influencers understand their value and negotiate fairly
- **Quality-first matching:** Platforms that prioritize content authenticity over vanity metrics

Interview 2: Call with Dheeraj (Divye)

Analysis of Verbal Cues

- **Community-focused:** "Through this community, I'm connected to a lot of skaters" - emphasizes relationship-based approach
- **Protective of talent:** Strong focus on fair compensation and skill-level differentiation
- **Business pragmatic:** "It was 50-50... we had to gamble a lot" - understands negotiation dynamics
- **Industry expertise:** Can assess skill levels and rarity of talent due to personal skating background

Key User Goals

- Represent niche talent (skaters) and secure fair compensation based on skill level
- Build standardized pricing structure for different talent tiers
- Expand network and increase deal volume
- Protect creators from exploitation while maintaining brand relationships

Main Motivations

- Passion for the skating community and putting talent on larger platforms
- Creating fair compensation standards in niche talent areas
- Building sustainable business model around talent representation
- Bridging gap between brands and specialized creative talent

Key Frustrations and Pain Points

- Brands grouping all talent under same pricing umbrella regardless of skill level
- Delayed payments and unpredictable client schedules affecting talent availability
- Lack of leverage when working with larger brands despite having exclusive access to talent
- Time-intensive negotiation processes without standardized contracts

Opportunities

- **Niche talent platforms:** Specialized marketplaces for specific skill-based creators (sports, arts, etc.)
- **Skill-based pricing tools:** Systems that help justify different compensation tiers based on difficulty/rarity
- **Contract automation:** Standardized agreements with payment protection (escrow systems)

- **Talent portfolio management:** Tools for managing multiple creators and their availability/schedules
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Interview 3: Call with Dhruv Gupta

Analysis of Verbal Cues

- **ROI-focused:** Constantly evaluating return on investment and measurable outcomes
- **Agency-skeptical:** "Maybe not [use agencies]... the influences we will try to get them individually"
- **Process-oriented:** Detailed description of production workflow and timeline management
- **Quality-conscious:** Emphasis on professional output and brand credibility

Key User Goals

- Create professional demo content for B2B-to-B2C market transition
- Build brand awareness and credibility in salon/beauty industry
- Generate qualified leads through influencer-created content
- Reduce costs by moving away from expensive agency model

Main Motivations

- Business growth and market expansion from B2B to consumer market
- Cost efficiency and better ROI on marketing spend
- Building authentic brand credibility through professional content
- Creating reusable assets for multiple marketing channels

Key Frustrations and Pain Points

- Agency cost inflation (₹20K to ₹30K) and lack of transparency in pricing
- Long lead times for connecting with influencers through referral networks
- Lack of creative input options - stuck with own perspective/ideas
- Limited access to diverse influencer options through current referral system

Opportunities

- **Direct brand-creator matching:** Platform eliminating agency markup while maintaining quality
- **Creative collaboration tools:** Systems for brands and creators to co-develop authentic concepts
- **Multi-purpose content creation:** Platforms optimizing for reusable assets across channels

- **Transparent pricing marketplace:** Clear, upfront costs without hidden agency fees
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Interview 4: Call with Sanjana Dixit

Analysis of Verbal Cues

- **Operationally sophisticated:** Deep understanding of campaign mechanics, metrics, and industry dynamics
- **Frustrated with system inefficiencies:** "It's not efficient at the current stage that it's in"
- **Highly analytical:** Detailed breakdown of engagement rates, CPV, CPM, and boosting practices
- **Industry-critical:** Openly discusses agency manipulation and brand misconceptions

Key User Goals

- Execute successful campaigns meeting brand-specified metrics (engagement, reach, CPV)
- Manage relationships between brands, agencies, and creators effectively
- Deliver measurable results within budget constraints
- Scale campaign management across multiple clients simultaneously

Main Motivations

- Professional success through campaign performance delivery
- Streamlining inefficient processes in influencer marketing ecosystem
- Building sustainable relationships with both brands and creator networks
- Achieving better matching between influencer capabilities and brand needs

Key Frustrations and Pain Points

- Brands imposing irrelevant restrictions that harm campaign effectiveness
- Lack of comprehensive tools for filtering and comparing influencers
- Manual vetting of large volumes of creators leading to suboptimal selections
- Information asymmetry regarding authentic vs. boosted performance metrics
- Acting as diplomatic intermediary between unrealistic brand expectations and creator capabilities

Opportunities

- **Comprehensive influencer analytics dashboard:** Real-time data on authentic engagement, audience demographics, and performance history

- **Advanced filtering and comparison tools:** Category-based, metric-based, and audience-based influencer discovery
 - **Campaign management automation:** Streamlined workflow management with clear accountability and timeline tracking
 - **Transparency layer:** Tools revealing actual vs. boosted metrics to prevent manipulation
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Interview 5: Call with Shourya Kumar Lal

Analysis of Verbal Cues

- **Industry-insider perspective:** Understanding of creator ecosystem from casting/entertainment angle
- **Cautiously optimistic:** Balanced view of influencer marketing's future potential and limitations
- **Creator-empathetic:** "They are actually confused" - shows understanding of creator challenges
- **Platform-aware:** Knowledgeable about different social media platform dynamics and trends

Key User Goals

- Cast appropriate influencers/creators for film and content projects
- Understand creator motivation and career trajectory patterns
- Navigate the intersection between traditional entertainment and social media influence
- Help creators balance authenticity with commercial opportunities

Main Motivations

- Quality casting decisions based on creator authenticity and audience alignment
- Supporting creator career development beyond just social media influence
- Understanding evolving entertainment industry landscape
- Bridging traditional media and digital creator ecosystems

Key Frustrations and Pain Points

- Creators struggling to integrate brand promotions naturally into their content
- Tight deadlines creating pressure on creators who lack professional support teams
- Confusion among nano creators about growth strategy and career direction
- Platform dependency creating career vulnerability (citing TikTok ban example)

Opportunities

- **Creator career development platform:** Helping influencers transition to traditional entertainment/media roles
- **Content integration tools:** Better systems for seamlessly blending brand partnerships with authentic creator content
- **Multi-platform strategy guidance:** Helping creators diversify beyond single platform dependency
- **Professional development ecosystem:** Training and support for creators to develop business and production skills

Cross-Transcript Affinity Analysis

Theme 1: The Need for Fair and Transparent Compensation

Core Need: Influencers and talent seek compensation that reflects their value and reach, while avoiding exploitation.

Supporting Evidence:

- "I had approximately 4 million views in the last 30 days. And based on it, the amount that they were paying... I feel that the beginner influencers, the small creators, the brands kind of try to exploit them." (Anupam)
- "At least a fair compensation. Like, you know, maybe if not based on followers and the number of views that we're able to get them." (Anupam)
- "Putting that price and negotiating on behalf of them, that's kind of a frustrating part... because people usually group all the talent in one umbrella and try to make the same price for them." (Dheeraj)
- "The agencies are basically like your managers... they take a lot of things into consideration" but "can take away your creative freedom" (Shourya)

Theme 2: The Search for Authentic Brand-Creator Alignment

Core Need: Both creators and brands seek partnerships where the product/service naturally fits the creator's content style and audience.

Supporting Evidence:

- "If the brand comes to me and I like their product and it fits... If it's too much, if something very odd... I'll probably avoid." (Anupam)
- "Would that be a deal breaker to you if in case a brand asks you to post something that you don't feel is authentic? Yes, 100%." (Anupam)
- "Influencers majorly look for... if that particular brand is aligning with the kind of audience which they have" (Shourya)
- "A female won't be promoting a men grooming product... brands even they don't approach it because they know that in their TG... they won't be able to convert the numbers" (Shourya)
- Brand managers need "what categories is this influencer promoting? What do they talk about? Maybe like a word cloud... some kind of statistical information that will help me understand this influencer is not the right fit" (Sanjana)

Theme 3: The Challenge of Efficient Discovery and Sourcing

Core Need: Both sides struggle with finding the right matches efficiently, leading to manual, time-consuming processes.

Supporting Evidence:

- "Sometimes I lose that message. So I'll reply to them after a week... their message sometimes gets lost in that all the other messages" (Anupam)

- "This reference route now takes a lot of time because I have to ask someone then they will connect me with the other person... if there is some tool... that will be helpful for me" (Dhruv)
- "I can't filter say by beauty influencer and see all the names of all beauty influencers, filter by follower size... that kind of tool just isn't there. That would be very helpful." (Sanjana)
- "If I can reduce down the lead time to reach out to an influencer, that is one [simplification]" (Dhruv)

Theme 4: The Demand for Creative Control and Input

Core Need: Creators want to maintain their authentic voice while brands seek creative concepts that resonate with audiences.

Supporting Evidence:

- "If we can get help in the scripting part of it or the conceptualization... if we can get some insights on how we can show it differently, so that would be really helpful" (Dhruv)
- "It should not look like an ad... it should be blended really well into whatever the concept of the reel is" (Dhruv)
- "The reason why the audience is there is just not being fulfilled [when brands override creator's style]... they're trying to push themselves on to them" (Sanjana)
- "A lot of the conditions that the brand was enforcing on the influencers were completely irrelevant and unnecessary" (Sanjana)

Theme 5: The Need for Trust and Reliable Contract Management

Core Need: All parties require structured agreements and accountability mechanisms to ensure smooth collaborations.

Supporting Evidence:

- "I would love to have that kind of documentation... clearly what number of hours would we require... how they are going to deal with it" (Dhruv)
- "Having somebody who can do it for them would be better for them... having kind of an escrow on the payments, that would also be very helpful" (Dheeraj)
- Contracts should include "who has the scripting responsibility... promotion rights... how much time each asset is taking... how many iterations" (Sanjana)
- "There's a need for, say, a contract or like a trust commitment... from both ends, brand and influencer both" (Sanjana)

Theme 6: The Pursuit of Meaningful Performance Metrics

Core Need: Stakeholders want to measure success through metrics that reflect genuine engagement rather than vanity metrics.

Supporting Evidence:

- "My current goal is to focus more on my content originality... money is not the motivation for me" but results-based compensation "could be based on the number of views shares some solid metric" (Anupam)
- "Number of shares... because views can be... boosted... but shares is something which is very organic authentic" (Anupam)
- "Influencers generally nowadays are prioritizing the number of shares and the number of likes and comments ratio" (Shourya)
- "The point isn't to get like a million views. The point is to get... 10% engagement... People actually should go and buy your product, not just look at it on Instagram" (Sanjana)

Theme 7: The Aspiration for Long-term Career Growth

Core Need: Creators seek to leverage influencer marketing as a stepping stone to broader career opportunities while maintaining their professional reputation.

Supporting Evidence:

- "Since I'm not that big of a creator, so my current goal is to focus more on my content originality... this is my secondary kind of work" (Anupam)
- "Influencers majorly are tapping into the entertainment side of the business. Either becoming a singer, becoming a performer, an actor, or trying to be a designer" (Shourya)
- "There is a certain confusion once you enter the influencer marketing side... you start to understand... a person becomes famous [as] influencer marketing, if he wants to do something else, he is prominently attached to [that]" (Shourya)

Theme 8: The Desire to Eliminate Inefficient Intermediaries

Core Need: Direct connections between brands and creators to reduce costs, improve communication, and increase transparency.

Supporting Evidence:

- "I won't hire an influencer agency as such... if the brand comes to me... I'll be happy to work with them" (Anupam)
- "Maybe not [use agencies] because... now shooting abilities we have... maybe the influences we will try to get them individually" (Dhruv)
- "Your concept idea is going to sting the agencies because... you are eliminating the middle man" but "the transparency between the creator and the brand becomes very transparent" (Shourya)
- "The agencies very easily defraud brands all the time... they have closed them for 8 and they're pocketing the rest" (Sanjana)

Appendix: Problem Hypothesis

Interview 1: Sanjana Dixit

you heard that right perfect yeah so I think first of all thank you so much for agreeing to this interview I think your time ready means a lot I will just start with your roles again I think you were just about to start with your role so could you explain to me your roles in branding marketing and similar areas sure

okay so I worked at Harper Collins I was in a brand marketing role there so we used to do some influencer activations as part of book marketing None of these were paid though. [J]

And then I moved to Dentsu. [J] There I had a formal influencer marketing role. [J]

The brand I worked with had very large budgets. [J] So we used to work in a mix of nanos, which is say 1 to 10K followers, micros, which is roughly 15 to 20K to 100K. [J]

Then came megas. [J] Then came celebrities. [J]

Sorry, sorry, sorry, my bad. Nanos. Micros, Macros, Megas, then Celebrity, yes. [J]

Got it.

Yeah, so five categories broadly. [J]

And out of these, what's the category that you've worked with the most?

I mean by volume, I'd say Nanos and Micros, but by budget, obviously, It just depends on the budget mostly. [J]

It depends on the goal and the budget. [J] So, for example, if you're looking for awareness, okay, the different marketing, the marketing funnel has awareness, consideration, you know, etc, etc. [J]

Yes, yes.

At the top of the funnel where you're just trying to make people aware and increasing your reach, your impression, your views, then you'd look at a larger celebrity, okay, because it will get more eyeballs. [J]

If you want higher engagement, then I'd go to a smaller influencer. [G]

So if you see nanos and micros will have a higher engagement rate than most megadons. [G]

celebrities because they have more time to engage with their audience. [G]

They can curate it exactly to whatever audience is following them. [J] So that engagement is more. [G]

Interesting. And how do you figure out that that indeed is your goal, whether awareness or engagement, what to optimize for is your goal?

So that depends on what we're marketing. [J] So if I have a brand, for example, I'm working on Durex. [J]

Okay, let me not digress. [J] Let's do Cetaphil. [J] Cetaphil has a cleanser that everyone is aware of, that gentle cleanser. [J]

It's maxed on awareness. [J]

Maybe they need to penetrate deeper into the market. [J] They need to increase engagement. [G]

So why would they need to do that? [J] Maybe they have a new product. [J]

Maybe they've extended the product line into a different, like say, a moisturizer or a sunscreen, which has happened. [J]

So if it's a new product, then you know, I want there to be a larger awareness in the market. [G]

So I reach out to a celebrity. [J] Okay, if I want say my engagement will be high, say for example, I have a discount offer that I want to use to increase sales. [J]

Then I go to the micros and the nanos and they give a coupon code, etc. [J] That will increase the engagement because their audiences are more attuned to, like say, replying to them and responding to them. [G]

Also, the trust factor is higher, you know, if the, you know, the celebrity has lesser amount of followers. [G]

But I wouldn't say a nano influencer has high trust. [P]

Micro to macro will have higher trust. [G]

Okay, so micro macro is the sweet spot for engagement oriented campaigns. [G]

Yes, but highly budget dependent. [P] So if I'm a larger company, I would do a mix. [J]

Okay, I would do, I would do mega macros, I would have like one headliner brand ambassador. [J]

Then under that, I'd have some micro and then I'd have nano do UGC, which is user generated content, right? [J]

Yes. For example, you know, I want I want people audiences to react to like, oh, you know, pose with your set of a cleanser and you'll get a 50 % discount on a moisturizer. [J]

So then, you know, there'll be more content online with photos of people, you know, with my product. [G]

So for UGC, I'd say more nanos. [J] Yeah, yeah, that's how I do it. [J] I do it as a mix. [J]

If I'm a smaller brand, I think I mentioned to you on text also, so there's two, a smaller brand can more likely not afford macro mega. [P]

Just to give you an example of what these people actually charge, say Tanmay Bhatt, for example, will take 15 lakhs or so, 10 to 15 lakhs for one post. [P]

So again, one post is not going to help you with a lot of awareness. [P]

If you just post one, that means nothing. [P] So mostly you do like one post, one story, one deal, you know, like a combination, so that there's like, you know, there's some consistency, like some continued impact over there, right? [J]

So if I'm a smaller brand, I'd look more towards, say, micros or nanos. [J]

If I'm doing micros, I'll do a limited number because micros can also cost, say, one to four lakhs, depending on their engagement numbers and their reach, etc. [P] Nanos, we also regularly do a lot of engagement -led activities with. [J]

So for a bigger brand, we do 1 ,000 nanos for one campaign or 500 nanos for one campaign. [J]

What smaller brands do usually is take maybe a mix of 10, 15 nanos with one micro, something like that. [J]

So the state of all of these together, [J]

that's what helps you actually increase reach. [G] Interesting. The scale at which you're, you know, specifying the numbers. [J]

So 1000 nanos or, you know, 10, 15 micros and all of that. [J]

It seems like sourcing could be quite an important part of that endeavor. [J] Could you walk me through that? [J]

How did you actually get through so many folks? [J] okay so okay i'll just give you a like a perspective of a small brand and a big brand okay so yes I used to work in HarperCollins, which is a, they didn't have budget, it's not a small brand, but they don't have budgets usually, okay, for these kind of things. [P]

So sourcing for that versus sourcing for, say, Setafil, or Darbar, or Durex, or any other bigger brand that's there, right? [J]

So for a bigger brand, how it works is, there are influencer marketing agencies, right? [J]

So, for example, there's LV, there's Quiroz, there's Mad Influence, there's a bunch of them. [J]

What they do is they aggregate influencers on their platform. [J]

Now while this is a platform -based model, essentially, where I as a company can sign up, make my own account, add influencers to a campaign, etc. [J] and reach out to them. [J]

I have never in my experience done the platform -based model because it's not efficient at the current stage that it's in. [P] What we usually do is the influencer marketing agency has one POC. [J]

Let's say if I'm a POC at LV, then I'll be responsible for five brands. [J]

And I have to now coordinate with all those five brands, see what their needs are, and deliver to them the influencers that, you know, they need for their campaign. [J]

So I'll reach out to the POC, you know, speak to them about whatever their available influencers are. [J]

They'll recommend me a list of things, and I'll have to, say, pass through their profiles and understand deeply about exactly what I need from them. [J]

If there are like, say for example, 500 nano influencers, I can't go through each profile. [P]

So that factor is very important. [P] And then we select basic benchmarks. [J]

But if I'm talking about a smaller brand, then I probably won't go to an influencer agency because I won't be able to give them the volume that they need, okay? [P]

how it will work for a smaller brand is I'll just look up and directly reach out to them on Instagram. [J]

So something that you need to do to be able to get that influencer mix without the support of an intermediary would be scanning social media to see similar companies and what kind of campaigns they're turning out. [J]

what the impact of that is. [J] So you can see very easily, you know, something has gotten more views, less views, more comments, how authentic the comments are, because there's a lot of, you know, fraud that goes on here also. [P]

People buy followers and comments, engagement likes, views. [P] So that kind of stuff, an analysis of what my competitor has done. [J]

Then I reach out to them directly through Instagram. [J] So this is a very long process. [P]

But if I can't afford to reach out to an agency and can't give them the volume that they want, then I have to do that. [P]

A huge time and cost saving factor of influencer agencies, is that they do all the negotiation for you. [G]

For example, I have a certain 10 lakh budget and I want 6 micro influencers, which is a very tight budget for 6 micro. [P]

So what I'll do is I'll tell them that this is my budget, this is what I need to do, you go and you get me this quality of influencer. [J]

So after I added the profile, it's up to them to do all the negotiations including cost, scripting, you know, your creative inputs and everything. [J]

So it's very hard to work with a certain level of influencers. [P]

After they cross a certain level, they become very picky, you know, with what they can do. [P]

Like, for example, I used to work on Harpik, okay? [J] So we needed toilet shots for all the ads. [J]

As you can imagine, some people were not forthcoming with using the toilet or showing them brushing their commode or whatever. [P]

So, negotiation for that, they use through directly. [J] So, they have that network and they have that relationship with influencers. [G]

So, that's how they save time for us. [G] Interesting. You did speak about benchmarking, I think, when you're reaching out for smaller brands. [J]

What exactly are the things that you were looking for when you were benchmarking? [J]

any specific metrics [J] so okay there are majorly so if we're talking only about instagram i think mostly in terms of marketing happens over there um so for instagram i'd look at engagement and i'd look at cpv um and cpm okay so in the cpv is cost per view so what is costing me for each view that this person is getting cpm is cost for thousand impressions [J] Okay, and engagement rate, which is basically any kind of action taken by the audience on the influencer's content. [J]

It could be a like, it could be a comment, it could be a share, okay? [J]

Could be like repost a story, whatever we want to really measure. [J] So these are the things you look at. [J]

As a person who has worked with influencer marketing agencies, I know that they boost. [P]

So what they do is an influencer will come with, say, views for marketing to a CTV of, say, 2 rupees, okay? [P]

This is extremely high. [P] What we used to work with is 0 .6 or 0 .7. [J]

So what the influencer marketing agency does is they boost it on their side. [P]

So if somebody is getting, say, organic views of 100K, they'll make it 250K, just to drive my CTV down. [P]

okay and while this is not above board per se everyone knows this happens so what you have to do while scanning and analyzing for competitive benchmarking is checking how many of those views are organic [J] okay so how many of those views and engagement you know engagement actions are organic [J] so comments also you can easily tell if something is paid then something is organic [J] Likes, unfortunately, you can't, but that's not something people invest in either. [P]

So views and comments are what people focus on. [J] Boosting is not a bad thing also. [P]

It helps increase your awareness, but you're understanding, okay, whether customers, if you're just keeping it organic, you're understanding whether customers are actually interested in the content material or not. [J]

So that kind of understanding has to be there when you're analyzing those benchmarks. [J]

But usually, an engagement rate of, say, 4 to 5 % is good for a micro to macro. [G]

For nano, you'd look at a higher engagement rate. [G]

Got it. But we have achieved with our nanos and micros, we have achieved like 35%, 18%. [G]

I think that is the mark of like a really good campaign, if people are very engaged. [G] Right.

35 and 18 do seem high ranges. [G]

Yeah.

Very high. [G] Yeah. [G] Absolutely. [G] So if you see, just see like it's just a simple thing. [J]

So for example, you and I on Instagram, we have like 400 followers. [J] right?

You can say that each and every person in your follower list is deeply engaged with you. [G]

You've at least met them once or you've chatted with them once or some kind of connection has happened, right? [G]

So out of those 500 people, 150 to 100 of them will like your content. [J]

So you've got a 40 to 50 % engagement rate as a non -influencer. [G]

So you see, as you keep growing as an influencer, your engagement falls. [P]

because you have lesser time to connect with each and every person in your audience. [P]

So if a micro has 5K followers, they'll be different segments. [J] Some will be younger, older. [J]

So based on your content, that's how their engagement will increase and decrease. [G]

So that's why if you have lesser followers, your engagement is usually higher. [G]

interesting wow and you didn't mention uh so trying to figure out if it's organic or inorganic after you boost stuff uh you said that it's possible for views and uh comments but not for likes [J] uh did they did i get that right [J] no it's not impossible for like so what they do is uh there's bots and then they have their own say accounts or the fail people to go and like and comment and share these accounts on Instagram, right? [P]

So you can you can increase likes but in my experience I've noticed people don't do much to drive up likes [P] they drive up comments or they drive up views. [J]

Got it. Because you'll see lots of videos with like I don't know 200k views but you go to the comments and you see 10 comments like that's just not possible [P] if 200 people are okay 200 000 people are viewing your video then they like at least some percentage of them will come and comment right [J] yeah so so you can clearly see that this is a promoted post like so that kind of distinction you need to see [J] and that actually tells you the value of an influencer like because [J]

boosted post, I can boost my post and I can get 100k views. [J]

It means nothing about the quality of my content. [P] It means everything about who I'm reaching out to and where I'm targeting and how big that audience is. [J]

So as a small brand, I would focus more on organic quality than I would on views. [G] Interesting.

You can just eyeball this stuff or do you use some tools to really disaggregate that? [J]

I mean, you just look at the ratios that 200k views but just 10 comments or is that enough for you or do you have some deeper tools to help you understand all of that? [J]

As a smaller brand, you don't really have tools. [P]

I'm not sure if they're there. [P] By the time I was in Dentsu, like we were working with the marketing, Influencer Marketing Agency. [J]

So they used to aggregate [J] I mean, we used to double check and corroborate, but it was manual mostly. [P]

No software tools were really used. [P]

Got it. And on that note, on the smaller scale aspect of it, when you used to reach out to influencers directly, how was that like? [J]

Can you walk me through how would you approach them? [J] What would a negotiation look like? [J]

yeah so smaller and so and so we usually have a rate okay [J] uh that uh like say 5k per post 10k per post [J] so you'll reach out to them say over email on instagram [J] they're usually very forthcoming like this is their daily you know whatever income so they need they do they do respond [G] um so they don't have their no intermediaries in the middle no managers no talent uh managers or uh you know any kind of person doing negotiation for them [P] so it's maybe like more direct but the advantage of having an intermediary would be [G]

that they already have [G]

cost lockdown with them. [G] And as an intermediary, I'm giving that one influencer a lot more work than just one small brand can, right? [G]

So they'll get a better rate. [G] So that difference is there. [J] Interesting. [G]

And have you ever encountered, I do understand they were forthcoming, but any rude behavior or any, you know, trust issues or anything in between? [P]

Yeah, yeah, absolutely. [P] So not when I was working for a smaller brand, but say I'm working for Denso, I'm handling two, three clients a lot of times. [J]

So this is, I mean, both the brand and the influencer can be blamed for this, I think, because there are certain things the brand won't be flexible on. [P]

So, for example, there was one video, a reel, where this influencer didn't have the best talking voice, okay? [P]

And the brand was not happy with just the way her voice sounded. [P]

And they then made us, you know, convince her to do a an AI voiceover or something like that. [J]

She was being very difficult, but like it's also the brand fault for, you know, bringing this as an aspect later in the process. [P]

Interesting. [P] Yeah. [P] I imagine that's a very unique position to be in man. [J] Yeah. [P]

The feedback, how it works is like you get like really harsh feedback and you have to, you know, make it more palatable and communicated in a productive manner to the person. [J]

So that was always a challenge. [P] uh there have been you know so again the agency creates like a they have the responsibility to make sure that the influencer doesn't just drop off the face of the earth and you know stops responding and collaborating [J] yeah so that is that i don't have to do as as a say campaign manager. [G]

They do it for me. [G] But if I'm a smaller brand, I will have to. [P]

So yeah, I think there is a need for, say, a contract or like a trust commitment or something like that is definitely there from both ends, brand and influencer both. [G]

got it and uh contracts and trusts i think uh i it does seem like both of these are pretty important uh what would these contracts look like [J] what would they have uh outlined [J] and how much do you leave up to trust [J] okay so i think the outline should include who has the scripting responsibility uh let's say frame by frame [J] uh who has the final say on you know video aesthetic, etc. [J] Mostly the brand will have to take that up. [J]

Smaller brands may not be too like pushy on this, but usually brands take this up. [J]

Then the terms including the final say whatever you're paying to the influencer. [J]

The collateral, like how many assets, of what nature, of what format. [J] There's also something called promotion rights. [J]

So if I don't take promotion rights from the influencer, I do not have permission to boost their content. [P]

So for example, this influencer makes a vanished video and I haven't taken promotion rights from her, I can't boost her content. [P]

That video is a complete waste to me, right? [P] Then there's also, say, on Instagram, there's different features like, you know, tagging, mentioning, collaborating. [J]

So all of that needs to be there. [J] I think another thing should be how much time each asset is taking. [J]

So between scripting, ideation, how many iterations, how much total time the entire process should take so that the reel is ready and posted. [J]

like that kind of deadline. [J] Usually it can take from two weeks to two months, you know, that kind of range is there depending on the influencer and how picky the brand is being. [P]

So that's something that definitely should be done. [J] I think that that should be it. [J]

Oh yes, iterations, like how many times the influencer has to reshoot the video. [J]

That has also happened and led to a lot of drop -offs because brands ask you to reshoot like maybe 3 -4 times sometimes, okay, which is extremely, it's a lot. [P]

Because the influencer is, you know, hoping to work just one shoot and done. [G]

But, you know, because of small problems like, oh, this shot is too wide -angled or there isn't any close -up here or, you know, stuff like that. [P]

Very minor things also they ask you to reshoot. [P]

So, if that is written down, then the brand also won't be too pushy about getting that done. [G] Understood.

Got it. So I see iterations, collaterals, promotion rights, all of those Instagram features like mentioning, collabs, time taken. [J]

Yeah, makes sense.

One more thing I would say, like should be there in this. [J]

So when you work with an agency, you have committed views or committed reach or committed engagement, like one metric they commit to you that this will happen. [G]

Okay, at least one. [G] So I think if you're working on a trust basis with an influencer, you should ask for like minimum amount of views or max accounts reached or something like that. [G]

So that there's some, you know, fixed value that I'm getting as a brand from them. [G]

Got it. Committed metric and that can be a reach or something like that. [J]

I think commitment would be a very like, I don't know, if that would work because influencers won't commit on their own only agencies commit [P] but you know some kind of understanding like I'm not sure how exactly to do this because this is a very big problem which is why the intermediaries are there in the first place. [P]

Interesting. [P] Because the commitment is just say they just will not you know yeah okay i will definitely get it because it's not in their hands technically [P] so you know how would they unless they also boost the post [J] yeah i imagine there's a lot of uncertainty involved up there and uh therefore they can't really commit [P] uh but it's interesting that brand agencies are able to do that [G] yeah yeah so they have the aggregate right they have like budgets set aside for this [J] So how their like revenue model operates is, for example, I'm giving them five lakhs [J]

for one influencer. [J]

Okay. [J] Whatever assets I'm getting them to make, they will drive down the cost of that influencer, like what they pay to the influencer by say, you know, they'll do two and a half to three lakhs. [J]

Okay. [J] Their margins are very big. [G]

And then they will use some of that, some of those savings to boost the post. [J]

So what, 10, 20 K will go. [J] And then the rest of that, they pocket. [G] Understood. Okay. And related. [G]

Yeah, go ahead.

Sorry. [P] No, they may also have volume deals. [G]

So for example, there's one influencer I know is doing really well in the beauty space. [G]

And I know, okay, I have some beauty brands that I'm, you know, constantly in touch with. [J]

So I might tell that beauty brand, like that beauty influencer, I'm going to give you five reels in the next three months, give me a very low rate. [J]

So it'll be like an aggregated amount you're spending there. [J]

But to the brand, you're giving whatever the going rate is. [J]

So there's like a huge potential for savings over there also. [G]

Interesting and how many of these volume deals would you typically have? [J]

Because I imagine there's a lot of strategizing involved. [J]

Yeah, I don't have that clarity. [P] But it's not difficult to project, you know, because you know how many brands you're working with. [J]

So for example, LV used to work with me, right? [J]

I'm in charge of 10 brands at one time. [J] So they know out of those brands, which ones are, say, sexual health, which ones are beauty, which ones are, say, automotive or whatever, they'll be able to bucket and [J] You know, so what they do is they stay in very close contact with the agency representatives to make sure they know which campaigns are coming, how much budget is there. [J]

So that kind of view they usually have. [G]

Got it. And relatedly in terms of budgets, what would you consider a small budget, a large budget and an average budget? [J]

From the point of view of, it'll be different for a small brand and a big brand. [J]

For a small brand, I'd say, you know, modest budget would be say 50 -60K. [J] Okay. [J]

Where I would take either one micro or, you know, a couple of nanos. [J]

A larger budget would be four to five lakhs where I'd consider taking a macro or a mega. [J] Okay. [J]

This would be like a larger activation. [J]

Personally, I don't believe influencer marketing works if you just do one level. [P]

I think it should be like an integrated campaign with different levels so that you're reaching people at different like, say, engagement, you know, levels. [G]

So that would be for small bands. [J]

For a bigger brand, we've had like large campaigns where we did like that, you know, 500 to 1,000 nano thing I was talking about. [J]

We had a two-year budget for that. [J]

Wow. [G] Yeah. [G] So, and then if you take a smaller budget, like maybe 10 to 15 lakhs. [J] Got it. [J]

So minimum like two, three influencers, like micro slash mega. [J] are there. [J]

If you're doing a campaign, you know, this amount of money has to be put in. [J] Interesting. [G]

The order of magnitude is significantly different between the small and the large brands then. [P]

Very less middle ground because the large is that - [P] It's also for platform collaboration. [J]

So influencers are individuals, but like there's platforms, say for example, iDiva was there. [J]

There's ScoopWhoop, there's, you know, BuzzFeed and, you know, you want to sometimes collaborate with them also. [J]

So, for example, we did one collaboration with ScoopWhoop for Psafe or like not Psafe, but like one of their like, you know, those products for cleaning commodes for traveling. [J]

And we collaborated with ScoopWhoop there. [J] I think the total amount was like 25 to 30 lakhs. [J]

And they did like a full video or their usual videos that they do, right? [J]

Like they interact with audiences and they just go out into public and ask people questions. [J] Right. [J]

And we converted that into an ad. [J] The entire thing, like 20 minute video was an ad. [J] Got it.

those kind of, I think it's very hard to reach out for small brands to reach out to these, you know, bigger platforms, because they also don't pay, because they think, okay, first, you know, small brands only won't be able to pay, which is very true. [P]

But sometimes if you have a certain budget, you want an article or you want to post or something, you know, that kind of outreach, should be better. [G]

And then, again, with the bigger platforms, the problem is that they take a long time, okay, from ideation to actual final product. [P]

And smaller brands usually don't have that time. [P]

So, for example, if I'm a small brand, I have a Diwali campaign because I have, say, I'm a bakery, and I have some new package, Diwali package. [J]

I want the turnaround time to be 20 minutes. [G] days, right? [J]

I can't wait for 6 months for these people to get their content together and stuff. [P]

So that is also a roadblock. [P]

Got it.

But what would an average time be for a larger brand? [J]

Smallest 10-15 days. [J]

Oh, turnaround time for an influencer campaign? [J] For a larger brand, like what would be the amount of time they would expect or they would give you for any sort of campaign? [J]

So you're talking about a platform, right? [J] Like ScoopWhoop, for example, if I'm collaborating with them. [J]

Yeah.

Okay. [J] It took like three, four months from IDH, like from after we, you know, after we locked down the cost, like what we're supposed to pay to them, it took around three to four months. [P]

Okay. [P] Wow. [P] Interesting. [P] Again, both sides, like the brand was very inflexible and they were like, it was very close to being terminated, the contract, because of the back and forth that was happening. [P]

So it's very tricky, which is why I mean, I'm sure your product, you know, wants to do away with human intervention, but just explain to you why human intervention is important in this space. [P]

I'm sure there's a way that tech or like say contracts or you know, some kind of platform trust you know, model could help take care of that. [G]

But at the moment, the current influencer marketing agencies just cannot provide that apart from humans coming in and doing all the negotiation for you. [P]

Yeah, I think the negotiation aspect and, you know, just working with the influencers and, you know, acting as those intermediaries seems like that they do play an outsized roles. [J]

Yes. [J] And then you can imagine in India, like lots of people say lots of Nanos are, you know, women at home. [J]

That's what I have noticed a lot. [J] of them are mostly just females at home, like mothers, housewives, homemakers. [J]

So, you know, they maybe haven't been through, like, professional experiences, so they won't understand the importance of, like, if a brand is telling me to do this and I just have to do it and that's how I get my money. [P]

You know, they push back, they're, you know, maybe, you know, it's just not the same background as what you would expect in any other brand. [P]

country like maybe like a western country [P] i see what you're saying [J] yeah and uh what were the like the biggest uh points of frustration in your work then in general [P] uh biggest point i would i think my are you are you talking about me as a brand or me as a person working with a brand [J] you as a person [J] you as a person working with a brand [J] Oh, okay. [J]

Well, I think that a lot of the conditions that the brand was enforcing on the influencers were completely irrelevant and unnecessary. [P]

Okay. [P]

So there's a need for, you know, some kind of structure to what they're asking for. [G]

And then, you know, you can't really question if they're paying you, you can't really question them why you wanted a certain way or whatever, even if it doesn't make sense. [P]

So we'd have a lot of, you know, back and forth because of that. [P]

Another point of frustration I think would be, similarly from the influencers, it was just a human misunderstanding that happens in this kind of process. [P]

At the same time, while I was doing influencer marketing, I'm also handling digital platforms and campaign setups and ads on OTTs. [J]

Things were very different because as soon as humans come into play, there's a lot of conditions that just can be eradicated if there's just a general contact or something like some binding document that [G]

lays out what you have to do for how long and how many iterations. [G]

So I think that was a major pain point. [P]

Interesting. [P]

And with regards to the first point really, I think brands imposing unnecessary restrictions, do brands in general have more power in the relationship or do you feel certain times influencers do? [P]

Brands have the most power in most situations because they put all the pressure of getting things done to intermediaries like me and the influencer marketing agency. [P]

They'll just be like, here, I want this influencer at this cost and this CPV and this engagement rate. [P]

I don't care, just do it. [P] So that's the kind of attitude they have. [P]

Most of the pressure falls on the intermediaries there. [P]

When the power is used the other way, which is towards the influencers, if the person is very important to the campaign or they're just major. [J]

So, for example, if we're working with like a celebrity, like say Alia Bhatt or someone, then there's nobody has any power but Alia Bhatt there, right? [P]

Yeah.

Even mid -tier influencers, like we work with, you know, Aishwarya Mohanraj. [J] I don't. [P]

Okay, so like she's in a Tanmay Bhatt gang. [J] Okay. [J]

In fact, Tanmay Bhatt like was one person we wanted for the campaign and he just would not drive his price down from 20 lakhs. [P]

Like we had to let go of that because he wouldn't take like a lakh less. [P]

So in those sense, in that sense, if an influencer has enough following and weight, then they will not budge. [P]

So they have more power in that case. [P] Interesting. Okay.

Yeah.

i think also just information wise also i think a bigger pain point was just how Just getting the stats was very difficult. [P]

Like just getting, okay, what is an average engagement? [P] Like I'd have to just go and estimate that, right? [P]

So, and also a lot of the, say, you know, some brand manager at Reckitt really likes Jim Sarb, okay? [P]

And his engagement rate is absolutely terrible, like 1%, 2%. [P]

They will just force us to take him on and then they will say, oh, deliver all the metrics to us. [P]

You know, you know, that kind of, just lack of information that say you know they're biased towards themselves so they'll just get him and then they'll expect other people to get all the delivery metrics [P] so if there's like a say like a dashboard of information on metrics uh for each influencer it'd be very easy for us to tell them okay this person does not work like removes [G] so that kind of understanding would also be nice [G] otherwise how would you get those metrics [J] the brand uh the influencer aggregators would give that to you [J] Yes, Influencer Aggregator [J]

would give that to me or I would have to get it myself. [J]

So Influencer Aggregator has a platform which I can go on and I can search and see and get things [J] but like there isn't a... [P] I can't filter say by beauty influencer and see all the names of all beauty influencers, filter by follower size or you know influencer category like that kind of tool just isn't there. [P]

That would be very helpful. [G]

Okay, so Influencer Aggregators don't have that right now is what he is telling me. [P]

They don't have a central dashboard as far as I know. [P]

You can just go log on to some and see, make your own account. [J]

By the time when I was there, I could search for influencers separately, like I could search for Tanmay Bhatt separately and get, okay, this is the amount of views he gets and impressions. [J]

and reach and engagement [J] but I won't be able to compare [P] like I can't sit and say all the comedy influencers in India and you know what they get [P] I don't think that facility was there when I left [P] but but they are trying to infuse AI into the whole thing but it is not working [P] it just isn't there [P] and honestly the brands don't want it [P] like they don't want to not have human intervention I think, not because it won't be better, but because they're just resistant to digital change, I think. [P]

Interesting.

Wow. [P] Okay. [P]

It's fascinating that these things aren't available. [P] You would think that they are, but they aren't. [P] Wow. [P]

I'm sure they're available, but like I said, the brands we work for now, they're very Lala type. [P]

Like there's no startup that goes and looks for influencer marketing through agencies, right? [P]

They do it themselves or they do it maybe more efficiently also. [G]

The companies that I work, say for example, Darbar. [J] Okay, Darbar is getting influencers. [J]

You can imagine, you know, they want Ayurveda and spiritual and people like that who really won't be as tech savvy. [P]

So that is there. [P] But I do think that kind of dashboard, those kind of metrics at a glance, that information would be very time -saving, cost -saving in general. [G]

Wow, interesting. [G] Got it.

And in general, I think, what has the trend in terms of the importance of influencer marketing that you see from these brands? [J]

So, generally, globally, influencer marketing has become one of the most important things now because everyone is on Instagram, but the problem is that is distinguishing between good content and bad content, okay, which a lot of people aren't doing. [P]

So all the nano campaigns that we ran, the quality of the influencers was very suboptimal, let's say, okay. [P]

Being kind here. [P] But, you know, just the thing is, because I didn't like, I didn't have time to go through all those thousand profiles. [P]

There is a certain trust level I had with the agencies. [G]

I could manually go click on 50 of those and tell them the problems, but there was no actual way. [P]

So these people, they didn't know how to write captions. [P]

I had to write captions for all of them on my own. [P]

So that kind of problem is also that you can't really get any commitment on the quality, I think. [P]

I understand. [J] Interesting. [G]

I think we've covered quite a breadth of things. [G] Is there anything else you think I might have missed asking you that you would want me to know? [J]

I think you should definitely go on an influencer platform and just see how it works. [J]

I'm guessing you're trying to come up with something that will replace these intermediaries. [J] Yeah. [J] If I'm not wrong. [J]

Yeah, sort of like a... [J] Yeah, go log on, see how it works. [J]

I personally never thought it was very user -friendly or efficient. [P]

And then the brands also, like I said, they want someone to call and yell at, you know. [P]

They don't want to be talking to AI. [P] But I mean, they have enough people to yell at, so that can obviously be arranged for them. [J]

But yeah, I think the Influencer marketing is very, very important right now because if it works, it works really well. [G]

I've seen like restaurants transformed by one deal. [G] Like one person put this one good reel and then everyone is there. [G]

It's sold out. [G] so it can be very impactful [G] but the sometimes brand see for example I'm an influencer I know my audience I know what content that they like okay for example if I'm 100 200 K big right I know okay which segment I'm targeting I know what they want what information they want and I know what tone they want me to talk in [J] brand comes in and tells me talk this way write this promote this I have no power [P] The reason why the audience is there is just not being fulfilled. [P]

So I think that also creates very suboptimal content because the brand isn't leveraging the influencer's say tonality and attitude that has gotten their audience in. [P]

They're trying to push themselves on to them, right? [P] So For example, when we did say a vanish influencer campaign, we went to these like big boss celebrity couple and they wanted them to do it. [P]

What is the, why will I go to, you know, some big boss celebrity and see what they're cleaning the toilet with? [P]

That makes no sense. [P] So that kind of understanding I think brands don't have, again, because of lack of information, because they need to see, okay, what categories is this influencer promoting? [P]

What do they talk about? [J] Maybe like a word cloud or something like that. [G]

Like some kind of statistical information that will help me understand this influencer is not the right fit for me. [G]

Like that is not there right now. [P]

It is randomly, like some brand manager will be like, I don't know, Priyanka Chopra fan and just get her for like, I don't know, a crore and have no understanding of her fit with the brand, right? [P]

So that I think is also there. [P] Interesting, I think so what I understand from that is I think really matching the vibe of the influencer, their you know historical content that they've been posting I think to what the brand is looking for is pretty important. [G]

not a lot of brands understand how to do that matching or how really to interpret what the influencer has been working on. [P]

Is that the right way to think about this? [J]

Yes and another thing is that I think working with a new influencer every campaign is the way to go. [P]

It's a way to, I think, increase your overall reach, but it would be more impactful to work continually with one influencer and have, say, a contract spanning six, seven months where there's 20 deliverables, and have that consistency and continued engagement with their audience if they're the right fit. [G]

That just doesn't exist. [P] I have never experienced a brand saying okay to the same influencer twice. [P]

That's because they think, oh, more people, more impressions, more views. [P] The point isn't to get like a million views. [P]

The point is to get, I don't know, 10 % engagement, right? [G]

People actually should go and buy your product, not just look at it on Instagram and scroll through it. [G]

I think that understanding is also not there. [P] Interesting. [G] Wow. [P] Okay. [J] Just note that down. [J]

Also, because of the lack of understanding, the agencies very easily defraud brands all the time. [P]

So, for one influencer, I think we were paying like, I don't know, 15 -16 lakhs and the agency texted me by mistake, oh, I closed her at 7 or 8. [P]

So, I got that information that they have closed them for 8 and they're pocketing the rest. [P]

I mean, I won't go and tell the brand that, hey, they're taking this much money because they also need to earn money. [J]

And honestly, I don't care about a brand losing money, whatever. [P] But I need to achieve. [J]

The thing is, they tell me, get this metric. [J]

OK, now I tell the influencer agency, get this metric. [J] They can get it in any way. [J]

They can either drive down the cost or they can increase the views. [J]

and obviously they do the latter because it's easier for them to do that. [P]

So because of the lack of understanding that brands have like they don't they're like maybe short change and they're not getting the impact that they wanted in the first place. [P]

I see.

but the information again like i'm sorry i'm going on and on but like information will only be uh relevant for smaller brands like a brand manager at darbar is not going to go and try to learn about this stuff [P] they'll just be like i like piyanka chopra get her you know [P] yeah so they have that recall so i think they'd go for her and i miss out quite a bit of nuance if you have that sort of thinking and i think uh i think what you've described really well is the implications when it comes to [J]

that sort of thinking you miss out on a lot [P] Yeah. [P] Interesting. [P] Let me just check. [J]

Yeah, I think we've covered basically all the questions. [J] Anything else you want me to know? [J]

No, I think I'm good. [G]

If I think of anything else, I'll drop you a text and maybe we can connect again or something. [G]

But I think I've told you end to end how it works usually. [G] Absolutely. [G] Got it. [G] Got it. [G] One second. [J]

I'll stop the recording then. [J]

Interview 2: Dhruv Gupta

Were you able to hear that? Yeah, yeah, perfect. So let's start. Thanks a lot for your time for this interview [J] Uh, we'll just start by talking about uh What would you aim as a brand? [J] Uh, why would you want to work with influencers? [J] So, uh, basically, uh influencers are gonna help us to reach out to the masses [G] What currently we have is a b2b product [J] But yes as we are going to b2b to c so we need to create some awareness in the market and as our product [G] Quite aligns with the demands of the user. [J]

We need to you know, just Make them aware of this kind of solution does exist [G] And that's where I feel that influencers and basically social media influencers are going to help us a lot [G] perfect [G] Uh, have you worked with influencers in the past? [J] Yeah, so I have worked with an agency not directly with the influencer [J] So the agency did provide me with a model and influencer and yeah complete [J] They actually had the influencer as well as a complete setup to record. [G] Uh, you know Demo of the product and everything around it [J] Interesting kind of one-stop solution for me for everything. [G] Yeah.

How did you find out about the agency? [J] So, uh this agency I got the reference from one of my friends. [J] So Actually, we had the product there in hyderabad and we actually required some agency from Hyderabad itself. [J] So that's why I contacted one of my friends [J] My college friend who lives there and he Introduced me to one of the persons. [J]

He had worked with them previously [J] So he had a good experience and that's how we got connected with that agency [G] got it and uh What was the rating rates of that agency like? [J] So to the best of our memory, uh, I guess we paid them initial quote was about uh, 20,000 which included the shoot and definitely the charges of the basically the influencer or whatever model you can call them and then the You know equipment they brought in their equipments to shoot and everything [J] So end to end initial quote was 20,000, but it also included editing and everything. [J] So ultimately the video costed me about 30,000 Marks. [P] Yeah, got it.

That was the final [P] From your perspective what all work did the agency do? [J] So see initially started with the scripting and conceptualizing the entire video for me [J] So that involved a lot of efforts of us as well. [P] So because uh, The product was very unique and uh, we had to you know, tell them how we want the entire Journey to be [J] so we wanted to show the entire user journey to uh, basically to the users [J] so For that we had to you know work collaboratively with them for the scripting part of it [J] And then definitely we explained them the tool once the influencer as well as the shooting team [J] We explained everything actually the thing was that because the smart mirror had a reflection to it [P] So we had to define perfect angles for [J] it So that uh, you know, the video can be shot perfectly without any reflections hindering [P] And yes, once those things were in place, then it took a complete day for us to be there [P] To you know, we started the uh shooting in the morning about I guess 10 when the salon opened [J] And then it went on till like 9 p.m [P] In the evening, we took a small one hour break in between and that's all [J] so it took long to you know Just shoot it because it was so many things and then ultimately the video came [P] out to be what uh 40 or 50 second video that actually we uploaded [J] So yeah, that's how the process was [J] And it ended till editing as well because a complete shooting day one entire day shooting then They shared all the raw clips with me and then we went on to editing part of it [J] We gave them the complete flow how we want the script to be done and then definitely one more process part of it was Getting the voice recorded. [J] So because uh the script had to be read by someone so we actually contacted one of our Friend who has been working as a radio jockey [J] So she actually helped us to you know, because she recorded in her voice. [G]

We actually did that Apart from the video agency [J] So we actually hired her for this purpose and she gave us the complete recording of her voice [G] For the script and that's what we added for the final video [J] Got it. And how did the video do? [J] So the video did pretty well because we added it as a collaboration so we collaborated with the salon partner and then we posted it and About what I remember at that time Very initial days of it. [J] We got 4k views in I guess 24 hours. [G]

So because that was the first Collaborated video that we added to our page with the influencer with the brand and Yes, so considering that for us, it was a great reach [G] Got it. So you seem to be satisfied with how the video did then in general? [G] Yes Definitely is because yeah, we got about 4000 views in 24 hours, which was

sufficiently good for us to you know initially build some credibility around what we are doing [G] and Yeah, just to you know grow the page slowly and slowly that was the first step towards that [J] And when you reached out to the agency or when you were conceptualizing that you need to create an output like that [J] What was your original goal or intention of doing it? [J] For example, was it engagement reach? [J] What were you looking for? [J] Actually, to be honest multiple things. [J] So we wanted we had no video no professionally shot videos of our smart mirror [P] So what we wanted is one we wanted some videos some clippings of that video for the website [J] Then we definitely wanted to post this video on social media to create awareness as I said [J] And then definitely uh, because after that we have been sharing those videos with all our clients [J] So whoever wants to have a look at what the smart mirror is and what it does [J] So to give them a complete idea before even connecting with us over a call or [J] maybe in person [J] We share the video across and that basically works as a demo video for them. [J]

So yes overall it helped us in various various different compartments of it [G] and that's how it kind of was really helpful for us considering We went on paying 13000 for the entire project [J] So yeah, that's where it has brought us the return on investment. [G] Yeah [G] Got it [G] if you were would you be able to put a monetary value to this return or investment or do you think that you know [J] Uh, or is there another way you're judging the success? [J] currently, I won't uh You know go for a metric on monetarily [P] Okay, how much I paid for it or how much did I get out of it? [J] But yes more than monetary benefit. [G] It actually uh helped us, you know create a lot of Leads so to be honest because uh with this video we got So many leads on our website itself. [G]

So whether it be domestic leads or even international leads [G] so That way it helped us get leads from maybe middle east or even some leads from europe [G] so I don't know maybe this video got shared over some groups of theirs because uh The community that we are targeting is salon community and among that community the connections are really strong [G] so they share Such new things with each other very fast. [G] So yes, that's how we got a lot of leads and we are With some we actually got converted [G] We could get the ideas converted into actually operations and with some we are still in talks. [J] So yes, uh, I cannot Judge it on some actual metrics of how much monetarily it helped us definitely did help us [P] But yeah more than that it helped us build a credibility [G] And you know, it gave us a channel to you know, communicate with so many people who initially we were actually going for inbound [P] Inbound, so we were actually uh calling them or mailing them [P] So cold mailing and those things were not working for us with this [P] Sorry, we were going for an outbound kind of strategy. [P]

But yeah with this we got inbound clients and they were actually calling us [G] Do you want a meeting or something like that? [G] So yeah [G] That's how it worked in our favor [G] Got it and where does influencer given your experience and given your future focus where does influencer marketing Stand with respect to the rest of your marketing budget and aims [J] Actually, uh I mean, I cannot give you any percentage of it or something because currently we have not done a lot of marketing. [P] But yes, uh going ahead we have thought of collaborating with influencers who You know can because what I feel influencers are looking for such kind of products which are unique [G] so even their audience would like it [G] And for us It is a good fit if we can get some influencers to talk about it [G] And you know create some awareness in their audience or maybe whatever audience you can cater with them. [J] So yeah, uh, I guess we have two major things one is Whichever brand we are collaborating with so the salon brand has some value With their page. [J]

So the collaborated post does help us in that those things [G] That is one chunk of it and the other chunk of it is with the influencers [J] So these are the two ways we see how we are, you know gonna do the social media marketing [J] And one is influencers and other is yeah the collaboration with the brand [J] Understood. [J] Okay, and in future influencer marketing, uh, how would you go about it? [J] Would you retain your way of going to the agencies? [J] um, maybe not maybe not because uh Agency actually was required initially for us to you know, help us shoot. [J] So now shooting abilities we have Got few freelancers as well. [G]

So through them we can do that and then maybe the influences we will try to Get them individually, but if that doesn't work, definitely we will be going back to agency as well [J] So whatever works for us, but yes, we will have to collaborate with influencers on those regards and because What I feel is I've actually seen uh, to be honest. [J] I've seen there are a few competitors of mine who have been, you know, uh publicizing smart mobile

phones, uh Close industry loads try on so I guess I remember some reliance brand was doing this thing [J] So they hired an influencer connected with them and they posted a reel [J] So i've seen a few reels of influencers doing this thing and that's how we also plan to do it in future [J] In the very near future we are planning to do those things. [J] Yeah [J] Got it. [G]

And what kind of influencers would you be looking for a certain segment a certain number of followers? [J] How would you uh, look at the influencers you want to work with? [J] Uh again commenting on a number would be tough for me. [P] But yeah, uh, I would see a target audience. [J] So target audience would be majorly For even for our idea we go for either the youngsters [J] So if some influencer has having some target audience of the youngsters, uh, especially in the metro cities [J] Or there is another big target audience for us, which is the females In between of you know, the middle-aged females like from 30s to 50s. [J]

So those are actually our customers [J] They are the major general of our customers and that's where if some influencer can help us to reach out to them then I would be uh, you know Definitely thinking of collaborating with them [G] Understood whoever basically, you know aligns with our target audience. [J] We would love to collaborate with them [G] Got it. [G] Okay and uh What would you think in your experience past or anticipated experience? [J] Would be some risks or concerns that you have while working with influencers and creators [P] Uh so see uh Risk point of view say I don't think [P] Uh The last experience for us was actually good until the influencer was involved in it [G] But yeah after that with the agency during the editing part of it on those things as I told you the code got uh, Extended so from 20 000 it got extended 30 000. [P]

So yes, maybe whenever we do it in future, we would be more Stricter to the you know initial codes and those things because once the codes get extended the things get spoiled [P] And yeah, I mean to be very honest, I would love to work with the same influencer again, but not with the same agency [P] So because in my experience with that agency was not great. [P] But yeah, obviously the influencer was Fine and that's how it went well. [G] So yeah, one thing I would make sure is that everything is well documented [J] And all the things are in writing with me so that You know, these discussions can be documented and there's no change in either the quotation or some DNCs after that [G] So got it. [G]

Uh You emphasized on uh documenting things and I assume that would involve a lot of contractual work [J] Uh contracting a lot of things. [J] So two-part question Who do you think should uh manage such contracts like what are the parties that should be involved? [J] And what exactly would you want to have in such a contract? [J] So one thing is yeah, it would be helpful if the agency has some uh properly made contracts [G] Though in my previous case also they had their contract, but yeah, it was not very well structured so because there were some key metrics which were not mentioned into it [P] like what would be the You know the duration of you know working [P] how long will it take [P] and how How many days of working do they include in this thing? [P] So yeah, there were a few metrics which were not in the documentation which we had discussed on text with them [P] We also actually asked them to mention it in the contract, but they didn't and yeah later we Understood that maybe there was some reason behind it. [P] That's why they didn't you know mention it in the document and that's how Our actually relationship was slightly spoiled with them. [P]

But yes in the future I would love to have that kind of documentation there that clearly what What number of hours would we require? [G] and Basically, yes, if it gets extended or maybe some requirement gets extended [P] So how they are going to deal with it or something like that. [G] So those things would be helpful for me. [G] Yeah [G] Understood.

Okay. Um in terms of Uh any tools that you might be using to uh find out creators or know about agencies or all or [J] Uh, if you were to go about discovering, uh influences, or would you just look at instagram or other platforms? [J] So traditionally what I have been doing up till now is definitely going by the reference of uh, the people who I know [J] So there are groups where I just ask for people like if you have collaborated with someone just share Across their number or something. [J] So maybe the agency or directly the influencer and that's how I get connected with those people [J] So that is how traditionally I have been doing not even through the social media like going through their Every influencer has some links. [P]

So not even mailing them and those things. [P] I have not tried those routes yet [P] but what I have done is currently, uh, I just got some reference from some of my connections and that's how I've gone about it up till now [J] But yes If there is some tool where or some software or some app where I can just go ahead and share my requirements [G] And then I can get that would be even more helpful because this uh reference route now takes a lot of time [P] Because I have to ask someone then they will connect me [P] with the other person and that Because more people are involved into it then the time, you know extends [P] But yes, if you have one-stop solution kind of those things, so that will be helpful for me because uh the time For the lead time to you know, reach the influencer and get the things done get reduced off. [G] So yeah, that really would be helpful [G] Got it. [G]

I would definitely have more things more options to explore as well [G] because through that means I only get one person [P] So I don't have anything to explore and do it or compare it. [P] Okay, this is better [P] So I don't have those things. [P] I just have to go with whatever my friend tells me [P] so because even in the previous case where I told you I had a Regulatory agency once the uh, you know relationships got in a bit then uh Same impacted with the person who gave me the reference of this He came back into the chain and then he solved those things [G] that was helpful for us. [G]

But yes Uh, if it would have been a tool, basically Some solution some app where I would have done this then it would have been more structured actually [G] Got it. [G] Okay. [J] Yeah [J] uh Beyond that, uh We've spoken about contracts we've spoken about risks and concerns, [J] uh tools that you might want to look at and how would you go about looking at and [J] Uh, if there is you know, one or two things that you could simplify in the whole process [G] Uh, what would those be? [J] Or the complete process of hiring and then completing in the entire process, right? [J] Yes. [J]

Yes [J] Uh simplifying I mean one thing is definitely as I told you if I can reduce down the lead time to reach out to an influencer [G] That is one [G] then the other thing is maybe the scripting part of it [G] So if I can because what happens is to be honest while we are scripting, uh the video If we are doing that everything we uh already we are, uh, you know working on this idea for last three years. [P] Yeah, we have Some thoughts in our mind and we actually boil down to those thoughts only so we have We have made a video. [P] So next video also there won't be some creative difference into it [P] It will be on the similar lines and similar way as we think about it [P] So if we can get a third perspective on the scripting part of it some good creative ideas around it [G] Maybe you can do this thing. [G]

You can add You know these things which will attract the user or give them a new experience [G] Why do we need to add a second video? [J] It should have some creative value to it, right? [G] So in those things if we can get help in the scripting part of it or the conceptualization of those things that would be helpful because uh There is one way we have built the tool and that's how we see the euro journey [P] And that's how we present it in our videos currently [P] But yes, if we can get uh some insights on how we can show it differently, so that would be really helpful [G] And sometimes what I feel is like whenever you collaborate with influencers because it should [P] not look like an ad right [G] Even if I see it as a customer when I see some influencer, you know marketing collaborating with some brand and you know Doing uh the marketing of that over a reel. [P] I just you know, uh, scroll scroll ahead [P] So in those things when it looks like an ad so Basically the user loses interest [P] but if it is uh, you know Blended very well in the part of that reel [G] Then the user, you know goes through entire reel and maybe sometimes they even share it [G] Because sharing is the most important thing if the user is not sharing it, then it won't help [P] So if you want the reel to get shared, I feel it should be blended really well into whatever the concept of the reel is [G] So, [G] yeah in those things I feel that the conceptualization And scripting part of it is really helpful [G] The basically the actual impact of the reel gets defined only by the script of it [G] So if we can get help in those things and creativity into those things, that would be really helpful [G] Interesting what I hear from you is a lead time be a creative input. [J] Uh, third perspective sort of a thing and uh, the third thing that you mentioned was uh sort of Scripting and the story of the entire video. [J]

Yes, that should be very organic and you know It should have some simple flow so that the user wants to watch it till the end [G] and it should not look like an ad [G] Got it. [G] So some authenticity basically some authenticity. [G] Yeah [G] It should not be pushed. [P]

It should be very normal and organic and very natural [G] I got it and uh from what I from what you just said, I also understood that sharing uh of uh Your sharing as a metric is something that you seem to give importance to is that right? [J] Uh, that is right [J] Up till now, but yes, in fact, it's on, you know changing things I feel reposting becomes even more important in today's time with the recent features They have introduced [J] and maybe in future more features will become coming but yes saved and shared Currently I just go by these two metrics [J] if some new metrics are introduced I would love to go by those metrics [G] But currently what i've seen is if the real is getting saved or shared These two are the most important factors [G] likes is good, but that doesn't give you reach [P] So yeah [G] Understood [G] I think we've covered quite a bit of things. [G] So is there anything else you'd like us you'd like me to know? [J] Uh, I guess Whatever I had to share on these things I have already done [G] but yes, um, Then because our tool with our tool many people have told us that brand collaborations will be that important. [P] We should go for influencers Helping us market our tool and it is very unique kind of thing. [G]

So because influencers For their audience, it's good. [G] And for us, it's good if we can create the awareness because you know, uh building something Which is actually creating a category is tough [P] But yes, it gets easier once you start creating the awareness about it [G] So it is tough only because you need to create an awareness. [P] There is no one else who is gonna tell people about it [P] It's a very new it's a fresh thing. [P]

Then you have to create a lot of marketing material around it [J] And that's where I feel we need to you know, we require uh connecting with these influencers [J] Agencies or even the guns. [J] Yeah, so that's how I feel about it [J] Interesting [G] duly noted [G] Yep, I think this would be a good time to Conclude the interview. [J] So thanks a lot for your time. [J]

I'll just stop the recording

Interview 3: Shourya Kumar Lal

You heard that right? Yeah So thanks a lot for taking this interview today [J] Could you just describe to me your current role as an influencer or your current complete role? [J]

So I am into film making, that is being a writer and a director [J] I also work as an editor and actor at times as well [J] So my interaction with influencers is basically immediately when it comes to casting for one project or the other [J] Perfect [G] And how do those influencers or how do you get discovered by brands? [J]

See brands basically connect with you given what kind of content you are making [J] If someone is doing basically, how do you say, let's say a creator has made a series of a certain event [J] Like say he plays a character in which he is portraying a school teacher [J] And then he has to do separate parts like parts 1 to 5 [J] And one of the videos tend to go viral [G] Of course there is no one such hit formula for anything of that sort [P] But what happens in that is that there is a relativity factor which the brands [J]

usually look out for [J] Like what is the TG of that particular influencer? [J]

What type of audience does she cater to? [J] What type of demographic does she come from? [J]

So brands depending upon whether they want the same kind of reach or the same kind of audience [J] Then they usually get in touch with that kind of a creator [J] Understood [G] You mentioned likes and reach and all [J] So what are the most important metrics that influencers optimize for? [J]

Influencers generally nowadays are prioritizing the number of shares [G] And the number of likes and comments ratio [J] Number of shares is because it also gives them this belief in their content [G] That this is something which is being shared by one person in their friend circle [G] Or anywhere for that matter [G] So the

number of likes and comments ratio [J] Which is basically also introduced to [J] If we talk about reels for that matter [J] So it's the number of plays on your reel [J] And the number of likes and the number of comments optimized [J] And the number of shares with respect [J]

to the likes and views ratio [J] Got it [G] And how does when we are working with brands or something How does contracts, payments and all of those managed? [J]

Like for example do you directly manage them or do you have people in the middle who manage them? [J]

See it also depends upon a lot of factors [J] For instance those people who are new in the game [J] You know compared to people with relatively new following [J] That is between somewhere around 5-25k [J] The followers bracket [J] So in that case what happens is basically none of these artists are managed by someone [P] So they usually come in direct contact with brands [J] Either they are connected via DM or basically they have an initial conversation on DM [J] And then brands send them an email Regarding whatever the material and whatever the promotional stuff looks like [J] In other scenarios when the [J]

influencers will establish [J] They are represented by agencies [G] So when they get contacted through agencies [J] Influencers usually don't have a lot of say in that [P] Except for the factor that okay I want to do this and I don't want to do this [G] So where your agency gets involved then the agency directly links it [J] All the remuneration and all that kind of stuff [J] So if it directly talks with the agencies [J] Between the agency and the brand [J] Got it [G] How is it like working with these agencies? [J]

See for agencies As far as I know a few people who are being managed by agencies [J] So I haven't heard anything where they say it's not fun or well written [P] Or anything of that kind of sort [P] But basically the situation is Agencies are basically like your managers [J] So they manage everything [J] This is the time to post [J] Now you have to schedule this [J] This thing is lined up for today [J] So it can happen sometimes that agencies can take away your creative freedom for instance [P] Because they want to optimise your social media [J] Which is not possible with [P]

a personal creator [P] For instance if a creator is not being managed by someone [J] Then he has to decide Today I can post this stuff and that stuff [J] And of course when an agency comes into the picture [J] Then they take a lot of things into consideration [J] What is good for your image, what is good for your PR [J] All that kind of stuff [J] Got it [G] Got it [G] And when influencers work with a brand [J] What are the most important things they look for? [J]

The brand or the influencer? [J] The influencer [J] Influencers majorly look for [J] See it again depends upon influencer to influencer [J] But one thing which majorly every influencer looks for is Basically if that particular brand Is aligning with the kind of audience which they have [G] For instance if I talk about A female for example [J] So a female won't be promoting a A men grooming product or any kind of that sort [P] Right [J] You know somewhere who is into You know Indian wear kind of and stuff [J] So that too suddenly Sneakers, joggers [P] You know the casual kind of western dresses [P]

They don't promote that [P] They don't do that [P] And brands even they don't approach it [P] Because they know that in their TG [J] Like whatever followers she has built They haven't come to this [P] So then of course Like they won't be able to convert The numbers which they want [P] I see [G] Got it [G] And what are sort of the What do you say The most frustrating things That might be in the life of an influencer [P] See majorly so it's basically of course Working with you know Impossible deadlines at times [P] That you have to deliver stuff by yesterday [P] Right [P]

So situation may be See everyone has a bad day or you know Times when they are not able to get the App script for Brand integration [P] because see a lot of The times what is also happening Nowadays The brand is not specifically Wanting the creator to make a reel For their product [P] Right [J] Like whatever content you are making Between that give us a mention [J] Got it [G] So aligning a lot of stuff into that matter [J] You know implementing that particular Branding to their content [J] Writing and Sometimes it can happen that you are Working on one project [J]

then you have To do a lot of stuff [P] Especially with the new age With the new form creators [J] They don't have a crew To do a lot of stuff [P] So then they have to Prioritize the work of the brand [J] So at times you know Other things for them like Their other content Some other sort of a reel [P] Those take a back seat [P] Right [P] Majorly there is only that Basically at times They have to Integrate whatever Brand they have To promote into their content [J] Got it [G] Got it [G] And in general Just generally talking about Influencer marketing [J]

How important do you think It will be For brands to Use influencer marketing As an avenue [J] There are of course different Placements and all [J] But where do you see Influencer marketing heading For brands [J] See influencer marketing Is definitely As of now Whether it will stay or You know Try in the future Is a very tricky thing to answer [P] Because at the end of the day For brands It's your product that has to speak [J] If your product is good [G] Yeah Influencer marketing For instance If we talk about You know a very Renowned face I don't know [J]

if we can take names [J] But if we talk about the rebel kid According to the rebel kid It's the same thing [P] He has followers [J] I don't know if his followers Will buy his product [P] And even if we see The comment section [J] Concerned with their imaging That we are connecting here [J] So today Something is up and thriving It does not guarantee That it will work in the coming future [P] So it's the same thing With influencer marketing [P] Because if we take a very big example Of tiktok for that matter [J] Tiktok was A very big thing During the [P]

pre-covid era [P] And after Tiktok was banned Big names from the tiktok industry Are Basically struggling to Make a name for themselves In the Instagram kind of a market [P] So that thing Is basically there [P] That it will always remain Very uncertain [P] Whether it's going to work or not [P] So yeah It's the same thing [P] Brands are also You know Just promoted [J] Instagram is the most Used platform in the Indian diaspora as of now For promotional content [J] X comes Close nowadays [P] But X's promotion Adds to it [G] For instance X is more Spread oriented Or basically Meme oriented [J] Instagram [J]

is more Real oriented [J] Let's make a vertical format [J] And promote it [J] Facebook's market Nowadays is Relatively on a low [P] But people do Run ads on facebook [J] Both managed by Meta [J] So Meta Also has Standardized the process [G] That if you promote on Meta Your promotion will happen On all three platforms [G] But if we talk about Indian diaspora majorly So Instagram is definitely Leading the market [G] With influencers marketing [G] And yeah X comes close second [P] Got it [G] And when it comes to These nano influencers [J] Influencers with Say between 5000-15000 followers As opposed to micro influencers [J] You must talk [J]

o a lot of These nano influencers Day to day [J] So where do you think Their mindset is at When it comes to All of these things [J] What are they most Concerned about [P] What are they most excited about [G] The one with The lesser number of followers [J] Yes [J] I can't speak for Everyone but Majority of people In my circuit [J] They are actually Confused with How they want to Grow their following [P] Because they think This is the way to Achieve their Dreams of Acting for that matter [P] Getting a base In order to become A content creator [P] So those [P]

things Are there [P] They are confused [P] For now [P] Even if it's Nano influencers A lot of big brands They also know It's a cost effective Method to promote Their brands [G] I'm not sure How other people Manage it [P] There is a certain Confusion Once you enter The influencer Marketing side [P] In people's Perception [P] You start to Understand In today's Reddit A person Becomes famous [P] Influencer marketing [P] If he wants to Do something else He is Prominently Attached to Or that [P] For a film He was typecast As a content creator Someone who makes real work [P] So those things Are there [P]

It's a never ending Challenge In order to maintain The balance [P] That makes sense [G] You raised an interesting point [G] Influencers are not just In it for money [P] You said they take it As a stepping stone To other careers [G] Like acting or Full time content creation [G] What are some careers Influencers Might be looking forward to [J] Influencers Majorly are tapping Into the entertainment Side of the business [J] Either becoming a singer Becoming a performer An actor [J] Or trying to Be a designer [J] A lot of influencers I think [J] A lot of influencers Have started a podcast Of one sort or [J]

another [J] So they are also Trying to expand [J] And generate revenue From YouTube [J] So majorly anyone Who is I am not Generalizing it Like visibility [J] So they are Expanding it To different formats [J] Understood [G] Okay Now what we have been Looking at My team and I [J] So we have been trying To build a platform That basically Helps brands meet Influencers [G] So brands can basically See based on their Campaign objective [J] Okay I want Engagement for this campaign [J] So I want 5 micro influencers [J] Okay I can search 5 micro influencers Easily on the Fashion industry [J] So that's sort of [J]

The use case That we would be Catering to [J] Okay [J] And directly help Brands meet These What do you say These influencers [G] So when describing An idea like this to you [J] What do you think Excites you about this idea [G] What makes you sceptical Or scared about this idea [P] Just one second I am getting a call [P] Just one minute [P] Can you hear me [J] Can you repeat the question [J] No worries [G] So did you hear the idea That I described [J] The question is What really excites you About that idea [G] What makes you sceptical [P] Exciting is of course The transparency [G]

Between the brand And the influencer [G] That of course Whatever the brand is Looking for [J] And what kind of influencers Are catering to their needs [J] So that transparency Between the creator And the brand Becomes very transparent [G] So that is a positive [G] Sceptical I am definitely Not sceptical [P] But basically I think Your concept idea Is going to sting the agencies [P] Because the agencies Bread and butter [P] Your concept Because basically you are Eliminating the middle man [P] And the agencies are The middle man [P] So of course They will try to Come in between [P] You may be able to get [P]

In touch with the creator [G] But a lot of agencies In that case Will try to get The influencers on board With their agencies [P] Because we will get You the right amount [G] Whatever kind of finances And things that we talk about [J] So yeah These are the two things Which I feel The positive and the scepticism With the whole concept [J] Got it [G] I think we have covered Quite a lot of my questions That I wanted to cover [J] Anything else you want me to know Before we conclude the interview [J] I hope I got the idea Of what you [J]

guys are planning to make [J] And I really wish you the best [G] But yeah I was happy to help [G] And I hope that You were able to get Some sort of knowledge Or some sort of insight From whatever I told you

Interview 4: Anupam Raj

Okay. First of all, yeah. Thank you so much for agreeing to interview on this. Basically, what we are trying to do is we're building a platform where we are helping brands meet influencers easily so that both parties can easily negotiate terms, see what works for each other and go about that. So that's why I have a couple of questions today on, you know, the world of, you know, brand influencer marketing and so on. I'll start with, you know, any general experiences that you'd like to share about the world of influencers or what's the first thing that pops into your mind? World of influencers are collaboration with brands. Collaboration with brands. Let's start there. Okay. So I did a couple of brands that reach out to me, but I did not like their, you know, they just wanted me to promote their brand in collab and in return. [J] They should have paid. [G] I think they just wanted to give me their product. [P] Okay. And I did not agree to that. [J] Okay. Yes. So in general, you feel it's important to be, you know, paid something fair, right? Correct, correct, correct. Like, you know, the views and that is that my account ad I had approximately 4 million views in the last 30 days. [J] And they've done it in the amount that they were paying. [P] So I feel that the beginner influencers, the small creators, the brands kind of try to exploit them. [P]

They try to, you know, get something out of them without paying them much. [P] Okay. Okay. In general, have you worked with brands in the past? Not directly brands I've worked with in use and all who have paid me fairly. [G] Okay. But with brands, it happened with three, four brands that they just wanted me to promote their brand and return. [J] They just were giving their product, which was not something that I wanted. [P] Makes sense. Makes sense. Your collaboration with NGOs, you mentioned what exactly did you deliver them? So they

were an NGO who wanted to promote road safety in Pune. [J] Okay. So I made a review for them promoting that road safety and posted that video in collaboration with them and they paid me accordingly for that. [J] Got it. How did they, how did they get in touch with you? Someone in their team, kind of, we're talking about it in a circle and one of my friend happened to like, you know, they told me about it. [J] So it was word of mouth basically. [J] It was word of mouth. [J] And in general, how do brands reach out to you, the brands that you were speaking about? They DM me on stuff. [J] They see my review somewhere, they check my account and they DM me. [J] Got it. In general, what mode of communication do you prefer when you're connecting with brands? For example, do you prefer face-to-face communication or is Instagram DM's also okay with you? Instagram DM's, if it's not very, so I get a lot of DM's. [P] Like, suppose I'm getting 56 DM's a day. [P] So sometimes I lose that message. [P] So I'll try to them after a week. [J] Then again, I'll open that Instagram section after, you know, few more days. [J] Then I'll reply them again. [J] So there it becomes a little tricky that their message sometimes gets lost. [P] And that all the other messages that are there. [P] Got it. Okay. Okay. And in general, do you know other people who've had similar brand engagement experiences as influences? No, I'm not, like, you never had conversation regarding this with other people. [P] Got it. Got it. No worries. No worries. What kind of, sort of, what's the rates that influences that you might know really charge for something like reels or posts or stories? Okay. So they charge something in seven figures. [J] Okay. Okay. And 15 likes for a one reel. [J] Okay. And maybe one tool likes for a particular story. [J] So they get to earn a lot. [G] But the small creators, they pay very less. [P] Maybe 3K, 4K. [P] If you have 10, 15, in K followers. [P] Got it. Got it. And how do you, are you actively looking for brand collaborations? Or are you just waiting and seeing if anything comes and you might engage with them? Actually, at this point of time, I'm not looking for any brand collaboration because since I'm not that big of creators. [J] So my current goal is to focus more on my content originality. [J] And because it's a very early stage, I don't want to, you know, anyhow influence my stories or videos with any kind of fake collaborations or, you know, so for now I'm not looking for anything else. [J] Maybe after I have maybe 10K plus, maybe some couple of brand deals. [G] But for now I'm not looking at such. [J] Got it. So you're waiting for about 10K plus before you actively seek brand deals? Yes. [J] And have you thought about after maybe you get to that threshold? Would you directly work with brands or would you hire an influencer agency to help you out? Would we have any thoughts on that? I won't hire an influencer agency as such. [J] Like what, according to me, if I, the brand, like kind of sorts of fits in my content. [G] So, and you know, they reach out to me because this is my secondary kind of work, right? [J] It's not my primary source of income. [J] It will never be. [J] At least from the near future that I see. [J] So this is not the best, you know, this is not my money. [P] Money is not the motivation for me. [G] Right. So if the brand comes to me and I like their product and it fits, and it won't take a lot of effort for me to fit that into my story, then I'll be happy to, you know, work with them. [G] If it's too much, it's something very odd, which, you know, some content that I never put, I'll have to do, then I'll probably avoid. [P] Hmm, understood, understood. Okay. In general, what are your thoughts on, you know,

if a brand is coming to you and they have an agreement with you, they put in a contract. [J] Just to, you mentioned exploitation at the beginning of the call. What would you include in that contract to make sure that, you know, you as an influencer won't be exploited? At least a fair compensation, like, you know, maybe if not based on followers and the number of views that you are able to get them. [G] So, you know, if I'm able to get them, suppose 50k views, irrespective of the number of followers I have, right? [J] Then it can be more based on results rather than, you know, pre giving us money because for them also, it's a risk that they are, you know, they can't give a lot of money to a very new content creator. [P] So, maybe it could be based on the results, not if I'm able to generate that much view on their product, irrespective of any content creator, whether famous or not, they should, you know, pay based on that. [G] It could be based on the number of views shares, it's some solid metric. [G] Got it. And what you, some metric you've mentioned, personally for your personal content, what is the metric that you prioritize the most? It would be number of shares. [G] Number of shares. [G] Yes. Because views can be, you know, someday Instagram, my booster is a bit more, or you can just boost it yourself by putting in some money, but shares is something which is very organic [P] organic. [P] Yes. [P] Got it. Got it. And one thing you seem to have mentioned that you would really focus if the brand really ties with what you're posting and you know, whether it's authentic or not. [G] So, is that something that's important to you? Would

that be a deal breaker to you if in case, you know, a brand asks you to post something that you don't feel is authentic? Yes, 100%. [P] 100%. [P] Got it. Got it. In general, what is the one thing that you wish, you know, brands did a bit differently when they're working with influencers? [G] Hmm. Keep up to date. [J] I haven't worked with these many brands, so maybe I won't be the person to answer that. [P] But again, on that point only, I think compensation would be one thing if I have to, you know, at this point, if I have to rank something. [G] Got it. Got it. In general, just looking at the big picture, where do you think influencer marketing will be in terms of the other marketing avenues as well? [J] So, do you think influencer marketing is something that's going to become big or is that something that will not be as big as people are anticipating? I think it's already very big and it will continue to grow. [G] The goal of marketing is to get number of eyes on their product. [J] And I think people, nowadays if you see that the end of people follow content, which they generally feel connected to, which they could relate to. [G] So, that is something which, you know, they get to know about a brand from there. [G] Personally, I have, as a consumer, I have opted for so many brands because my, like, you know, favorite influencers used to talk about it. [G] And it honestly not because of paid brands. [G] So, and it, you know, so based on that, I think it will continue to grow as long as people, you know, continue to be authentic. [G] And I think that it should be much higher. [G] The conversion ratio compared to if you're just putting an add on TV or anywhere else. [J] The conversion ratio, which a content creator can give you, especially the small creators, you know, not that big. [G] Like, we are vices and all small creators, which people generally follow them because they like their content. [G] So, they, they can give a much bigger ratio. [G] I don't know why. [P] Got it. Yeah, I think that pretty much covers the questions that I wanted to cover today. But do you have anything else you'd want to share about this, anything that we haven't covered yet? Nothing that I can think of right now. [P] If I remember something, I'll text you. [J] Definitely, definitely. Yeah. I think that pretty much covers it. I'll stop the recording. Just a second.

Interview 5: Dheeraj Verma

You heard that right? [J] Yes. [J] Yeah, perfect. [G] First of all, thank you so much for joining me for the interview today. [J] I'll ask a few questions about your role as someone who sourced and matched brands with influencers. [J] So, on that note, could you just describe me a bit of what you've done so far? [J] Okay, sure. [J] So, for a few years, I have been freelancing as a talent manager, and where what I do is when brands, when they require certain talent, which is skating in my case, I try to like, I require certain talents for their ad shoots and brand shoots or something. [J] I help them connect with skaters and also act as skater's manager for negotiations and everything on their behalf and make the whole thing happen. [J] Got it. Okay. How did you go about selecting the creators that you recommended to a client? [J] So, this is a very niche area. [J] Skating has been close to me for a very long time. [J] I've been active in the circle for a very long time. [J] I've been teaching skating to people. [J] So, I like, through this community, I'm connected to a lot of skaters. [J] And because I wanted to do, you know, like put skaters on another platform, I actually proposed this to skaters that I already knew that I would want to represent them and try to put them into the content industry or the modeling industry by finding deals for them. [G] This was kind of already set up base, which kept growing slowly once like people joined and they got to know that I can represent them for such cases. [G] Got it. [G] Got it. [G] And in this whole process, what were the biggest point of frustrations or the biggest challenges that you faced? [P] Biggest challenges would mostly be that the negotiation part of it is definitely challenging [P] because I have to represent skaters and then you have to evaluate skaters on certain skill set and the requirement for the shoot. [J]

And then I have to make sure that people with different skill levels are also paid at different levels. [J] So, kind of making that standard setting that standard in the industry has been a little bit difficult [P] because people usually group all the talent in one umbrella and try to make the same price for them. [P] But then, given the fact that skating and reaching a level where you can perform certain tricks, which are also dangerous for you, that kind of requires, you know, like for them to be paid well. [G] So, putting that price and negotiating on behalf of them, that's kind of a frustrating part of it [P] and also delayed payment. [P] And sometimes when the things go off schedule and brands get, the clients keep delaying, that's also like in terms of shoot days and then the skaters have to manage their schedule. [P] So, all that's also a pain point. [P] You spoke about negotiations. [J] So, walk me through who you think had more of a power in that relationship and in what ways one party might have misbehaved, whether that's the influencer side or whether that's the brand side. [J] It's mostly 50-50. [J] My job

was mostly to represent the skaters. [J] So, I always try to make a very strong case for them. [J] So, and that sometimes meant playing with the risk of letting the deal go. [P] So, like it was 50-50, I'd say, because brands also require certain level of talent, which is not easily available. [P] And when they wanted to find skaters in Bangalore, like the main contact was me. [J] So, that kind of gave me some leverage because I was representing a lot of skaters, a lot of talent in that area. [G] So, that kind of gave me the leverage over there. [G] And brands, because they of course were powerful and they controlled the money, so they had some leverage as well. [P] So, in the negotiation, it was always like 50-50, sometimes more than that. [J] So, we had to gamble a lot too. [J] Got it. [G] Got it. [G] Makes sense. [G] Walk me through how you sort of understood how you're doing. [J] So, how did you measure your performance? [J] What were the exact metrics that you looked at? [J] To be honest, since it was more of a passion driven and freelancing driven enterprise, I did not do performance evaluations, [P] but we always tried to make sure that our next assignment would pay us more than the previous one, given the nature of the work. [G] So, if it's the same nature of work, we tried to make sure that this time we negotiate a better deal than before, given the fact that we have already performed well on such assignments before and we have proof of work. [G] So, that was one way we tried to measure. [J] Second was by the number of skaters that I was representing and the number of deals that I was able to crack. [J] So, it started with a couple of guys whom I was representing and then it started growing. [G] So, there were opportunities available at all the levels. [G] So, how well I was able to get jobs at each level or get the gigs at each level was kind of a metric. [J] Got it. [G] Got it. [G] And what were the metrics that you felt brands prioritized? [J] Brands were mostly concerned about money [P] because they did not have enough information, enough knowledge about what's possible on skates also. [P] They would just visualize a shoot that they wanted to do and that shoot will have cool skateboarding tricks and everything. [J] But when the logistic parts of it kick in, when they have to source such skaters, that's when it becomes difficult for them. [P] When they realize, oh, this talent is not easily found. [P] It's just that they have seen it always online. [J] So, can you repeat your question again? [J] Yeah. [J] So, you said brands prioritize money. [J] Yeah. [J] And is there anything else that they prioritize? [J] So, like reach or engagement or something like that? [J] Yeah. [J] So, reach and engagement, they always come with a mindset that this particular project is going to give them the result that they want. [G] But what they do afterwards is something that's not very transparent to me. [P] Because sometimes we have seen the content that we collaborated on perform really well, having hundreds of likes and shares and comments [G] versus there has been content which got no visibility at all. [P] So, how brands value it, that I don't know. [P] But during the whole process, they want to make sure that they do it in least amount of money [G] and they want to make it look as appealing as possible. [G] That's their short-term focus during that time. [J] But how they measure it is not something that I'm aware of. [P] Interesting. [G] OK. [J] OK. [J] And are there any negative experiences that you've had in these relationships, like certain brands behaving in a certain way? [P] Nothing too serious, but sometimes some big brands, when they reach, they try to feel that they think that they hold a lot of leverage, try to tell us that they can give us brand recognition and everything and try to lowball us on that point, that they can give us exposure. [P] So, these small things are there, but otherwise, it's mostly been comparatively smooth sailing. [G] Got it. [G] And how has your engagement been with influencers? [J] What sort of people are they? [J] What do they prioritize for themselves? [J] T

hey usually prioritize their reach, the better it grows, the better it's for them in the future. [G] So, they would want more and more visibility and content that has the potential to reach a larger audience. [G] Got it. [G] Understood. [G] So, reach is what they prioritize. [J] It's kind of a trajectory. [J] Initially, they would want to increase the reach and afterwards they would want to increase the commercial aspects of it. [G] Understood. [G] Got it. [G] And what were the tools that you used in your day-to-day life? [J] What applications or what platforms did you use? [J] Mostly for outreach and portfolio, we used Instagram. [J] And for communication, it was usually done via WhatsApp or Gmail. [J] Got it. [G] Yeah, there were no other specialized platforms that we used. [P] It was mostly a lot of manual work. [P] Got it. [G] So, mainly, even for negotiation, you use WhatsApp and Instagram DMs? [J] Yes, I would talk to the client and then talk to the talent and then keep going back and forth on that. [J] Got it. [G] Did you do work via contracts? [J] So, did you create and have both parties sign contracts? [J] Yes, we have done a couple of such works. [J] Got it. [G] What did a typical contract include? [J] It would include the asset rights of, you know, once the shoot and content is done, who owns the assets and how it can be used later. [J] Mostly production houses will sign these contracts. [J] They would have the full authority of using it the way they want. [G] That's how we would sign. [J] And it would also have the compensation part of it, the taxation part of it. [J] And also some disclaimers on non-disclosure agreements on not disclosing information about the shoot or the product before they intend it to. [J] Got it. [G] Got it. [G] And just big picture, talking about influencer marketing and, you know, how marketing agencies and brands have been seeing it. [J] Do you think this is a big lucrative space or do you think that it's a space where opportunities will be limited as the time comes? [J] So, I think it's definitely a very big lucrative space. [G] We have already seen the era of, you know, like starting of creation from mass. [J]

So, mass creation has already begun and with AI, more and more people are going to be enabled in terms of content creation. [G] So, there'll be a lot of interesting content coming from people and a lot of people having a lot of followership, which definitely brands would want to leverage. [G] So, having an organized market for this is definitely lucrative. [G] Got it. [G] Going back to, you know, your day-to-day relationship with brands and influencers, what do you think was the biggest, you know, bottleneck that was in the middle of the relationship? [P] What really stalled things or slowed things down? [P] In terms of connecting with people? [J] Yes, connecting with people as well as working through shoots and all of that. [J] Can you, like, explain more on that question for me? [J] Yeah. [J] So, there might have been one or two things, for example, you know, lack of communication from the brands, proactive communication or delay in contract signing, stuff like that. [P] So, what exactly slowed these things down? [P] So, sometimes brands would, you know, like, go evolve because of, like, once they see the numbers that we put forward, they kind of take some time to respond. [P] Sometimes. [P] Some clients are really nice. [G] They would respond and respect our time as well. [G] But some definitely do delay these communications and then try to stall it so that we would give in first, kind of a negotiation tactic. [P] So, that was some delay. [P] And plus, sometimes due to the account section of the company, the production company making delays in payment approvals, that kind of delayed the talent payments as well. [P] Got it. [G] So, a lot of delays is what I seem to be understanding from different parties. [P] Case-to-case basis, the bigger the party is, the more levels and processes they have which delay things. [P] But the smaller the parties, they are more prompt in doing things. [G] Understood. [G] And what would make your job really easier in terms of going about your day-to-day life? [G] Are there aspects of it that you think, you know, we can automate or, you know, are things that you feel that aren't really important to the job but you have to do anyway? [G] So, I think if, let's say, if on your platform or on any platform, if I could find the kind of jobs which would be perfect for my talent, if I could find those easily, that would kind of increase the number of leads we explore and the projects that we do. [G] And if also they would help in keeping the contract process transparent [G] and having kind of an escrow on the payments, that would also be very helpful to, you know, like, do the gigs with more trust. [G] Got it. [G] So, matching and escrow is something you mentioned. [J] Yes. [G] Got it. [G] And is escrow something that... [J] Escrow is something I would say that's very contextual and subjective and depends on the project and it would require a lot of human intentions to write it very deeply so that the matching can happen efficiently. [P] But escrow is something which is universally helpful in terms of empowering the creators as well as the brands to have a fair deal and not hold money as leverage. [G] Got it. [G] Got it. [G] Okay. [J] And in general, you know, the things that you've mentioned, matches. [J] So, I imagine different types of influencers would look for different sorts of things when it comes to

collaborating with a brand. [J] So, what exactly is it that influencers are looking for when they prioritize such matching? [J] So, that is also very subjective. [J] For example, in our case, we usually had a very clear vision of just promoting healthy choices, like recreational skating and fitness skating. [J] So, when brands, very niche brands and new brands which came up like canned wines and everything, when they came, when they approached us, we did not take such projects. [P] So, that was because they didn't align well with our values. [P] So, that is one of the things that we like influencers look at. [J] Other things are their brand associations in terms of the other brand's image and whether they want to be perceived as such in their future as well or not. [J] But that's something that you do only when you have a certain level of follower base. [P] Otherwise, people usually go for deals because you have to start from somewhere. [J] Got it. [G] And talking again about the level of followers people have, what exactly is the general prices they charge based on their followership? [J] Do you have those numbers? [J] Yeah. [J] So, that is also something that we have struggled with because we did not have the transparency on that. [P] We had to figure it out on our own by doing trial and error. [P] Okay. [J] So, we had to set our own prices and then realize how easy it was for the clients to pay and then, you know, slowly adjust it as such. [J] And we also would look at what the skill level is and if you have already negotiated one price for one skill level, then how can we push better for another level of like one level up or two level up of skills. [J] So, negotiation and pricing was something that we struggled with, to be honest, and we have more transparency over that. [P] That depends on a lot of factors and a lot of things like what kind of creator you are and what can you bring to the table. [J] Got it. [G] Got it. [G] And when you first started relationship with influencers, you said that you really used Instagram DMs and WhatsApp to engage with them.

[J] How did you discover that they would be the right people for you to support? [J] Because they were doing really well in their skills, they came to the notice. [J] And once, because I knew that there was such potential in the market, since I had already done such work for other people, I kind of approached them and told them that they would be good for such gigs, and I would love to represent them. [J] And they kind of, they were very much agreed because they like, once they tried the negotiation process by themselves, then they realized that, okay, having somebody who can do it for them would be better for them. [G] So, these people agreed. [G] And since most of my target client base is young, they usually do not have such experience. [P] So, that's where I come in handy for them. [G] Got it. [G] Okay. [G] Okay. [G] I definitely see that you fulfill a need in that space. [G] And such people would require your assistance. [G] When you were looking out for talent again, specifically, you were looking at their performances, what you mentioned. [J] So, what were you going for? [J] They could show in skating because that was a niche that I was mostly following. [J] So, level of tricks that they can do on skateboarding, because I was able to assess that because I myself am a skater. [J] So, I knew what kind of tricks are really difficult to achieve and how much hard work it would require and how rare it would be to show it to anyone. [J] Got it. [G] Got it. [G] Yep. [G] I think we've covered pretty much all that I wanted to cover. [G] Is there anything else you'd want me to know? [J] Yeah. [J] On that last point, another thing would be, of course, the presentation, presentable looks, which we have in the industry. [J] So, sometimes that also comes in handy, having to define by the beauty standards of the industry. [P] So, that is also something that's usually done and required in the industry. [J] Got it. [G] Got it. [G] Duly noted. [G] Yeah. [G] I think this pretty much answers all the questions that I had for you today. [G] I'll just stop the recording. [J] One second. [J] Yeah. [J]

Use of AI

I used Claude (Sonnet 4) and Gemini (2.5 Flash) for this assignment.

You are a senior product manager with expertise in user research. I will provide you with a user interview transcript. For each line of the transcript, identify whether it represents a Pain (P), Job (J), or Gain (G) from the persona's perspective. At the end of each sentence, append the appropriate label in bold brackets (e.g., [P], [J], [G]). Do not alter or rephrase any other part of the transcript—only add the labels. Gain is a desire for a better experience. Pain is a frustrating part of their experience. Job is an activity or an exercise they do to achieve a goal.

You are a senior qualitative researcher performing affinity analysis. I am providing you with 6 summaries of user interviews in the area of influencer marketing. Your task is to identify and cluster common themes. Group direct quotes or paraphrased statements from the summaries under each theme. The themes should be based on user needs and behaviours (example - The Need for Precise Timing, The Search for the Right 'Vibe'), not product features.

These are my five personas of interest. Based on the transcripts and the personas, I would like you to come up with problem hypotheses, three each, for all of these personas. Example: "We believe that a freelance spin instructor struggles to create a fresh, perfectly-paced 45- minute playlist because of having to manually filter through hundreds of songs to find tracks with the right BPM and energy curve."

You are a senior product manager analyzing user research interviews. For each interview transcript I provide, deliver a structured summary with the following sections:

1. **Analysis of Verbal Cues** – Note tone, hesitations, repeated phrases, enthusiasm, or frustration that reveal unspoken attitudes or emotions.
2. **Key User Goals** – Summarize what the user is trying to accomplish in their work or context.
3. **Main Motivations** – Explain why these goals matter to them (personal drivers, professional success, external pressures).
4. **Key Frustrations and Pain Points** – Identify blockers, inefficiencies, or unmet needs the user expresses.
5. **Opportunities** – Suggest potential product, service, or process improvements that could address these needs or enhance the user's experience.

Keep the output concise, structured, and written from the user's perspective.